

[Asia](#) > [Southeast Asia](#) > [Vietnam](#) > [Northern Vietnam](#) > [Hanoi](#)

Hanoi

Hanoi ([Vietnamese](#): *Hà Nội*), the capital of [Vietnam](#) and its second-largest city, is a fascinating blend of East and West, with Chinese influence from centuries of dominance, and French *je ne sais quoi* from its colonial past. It was largely unspoiled by the modern architecture of the 1970s and 80s, and is now undergoing a rapid transformation that makes it a rising star in [Southeast Asia](#).

Understand

Invading forces from every direction agree: Hanoi makes a fine capital. It has held that title for more than a thousand years, through several invasions, occupations, restorations, and name changes. The Chinese conquered the imperial city of [Đại La](#) in 1408 and renamed it [Tống Bình](#). [Le Loi](#) repelled the invaders in 1428 and applied the name of [Lê Thái Tổ](#) ([黎太祖](#)). For his efforts, he received the crown and a slew of legends about his heroic exploits, many centred around **Hoan Kiem Lake**. The [Nguyen Dynasty](#) gave the city its modern name of [Ha Noi](#) in 1831, but they had transferred power to [Hue](#) by then. [Hue](#) remained the capital until 1887, when the French made Hanoi the capital of all Indochina. It changed hands again in 1954, when it was ceded to [Ho Chi Minh](#) and the [Viet Minh](#) after almost a decade of fighting, and it became the capital of North Vietnam. Upon reunification in 1975, it assumed that title for the entire country. (See also: [Indochina Wars](#)).

Hanoi retains much of its older colonial charm, despite the battles that have raged over it. Conflict had the effect of making it largely oblivious to modern architecture, and as a result, few buildings in the city center are higher than five stories. The **Old Quarter**, the area around and north of [Hoan Kiem Lake](#), is second only to [Hoi An](#) for uninterrupted stretches of colonial and pre-colonial architecture, well-preserved on dense warrens of narrow, wonderfully atmospheric streets.



Hanoi Opera House



Hanoi's Temple of Literature



The first Western-style universities in Vietnam were founded in Hanoi, and today, it is the leading centre of scientific study and research in the country. It trades the commercial boom and sprawl of Ho Chi Minh City in the south for a more understated charm, worth enjoying for an extra day or two; and with countless transport options and travel agents, it makes a perfect base for exploration of the North.

As you walk along the street, you may find that people start talking to you. It is a cultural norm there to make conversation with strangers. They might ask you where you are from and other general questions. But if you are a man, be cautious if a comely young lady approaches you and initiates a conversation - she is likely after something. It may take a while to get used to such overt friendliness, but it is worth enjoying it for the cultural experience that travel permits.

- **Tourist Information Centre**, Đinh Tiên Hoàng St. (*just north of Hoan Kiem Lake*), ☎ **+84 24 3926-3366**. Can provide a fairly useful map (bewilderingly, the blow-up of the old town is missing) and other English-language advice, as well as limited free Internet. (updated Mar 2025)

There are self-help information booths around the Old Quarter, but their purpose mostly is give the impression that Vietnam "has arrived" technologically.

Prepaid SIM cards for tourists are readily available at the airport arrivals hall and convenience stores. They offer generous data packages at low rates.

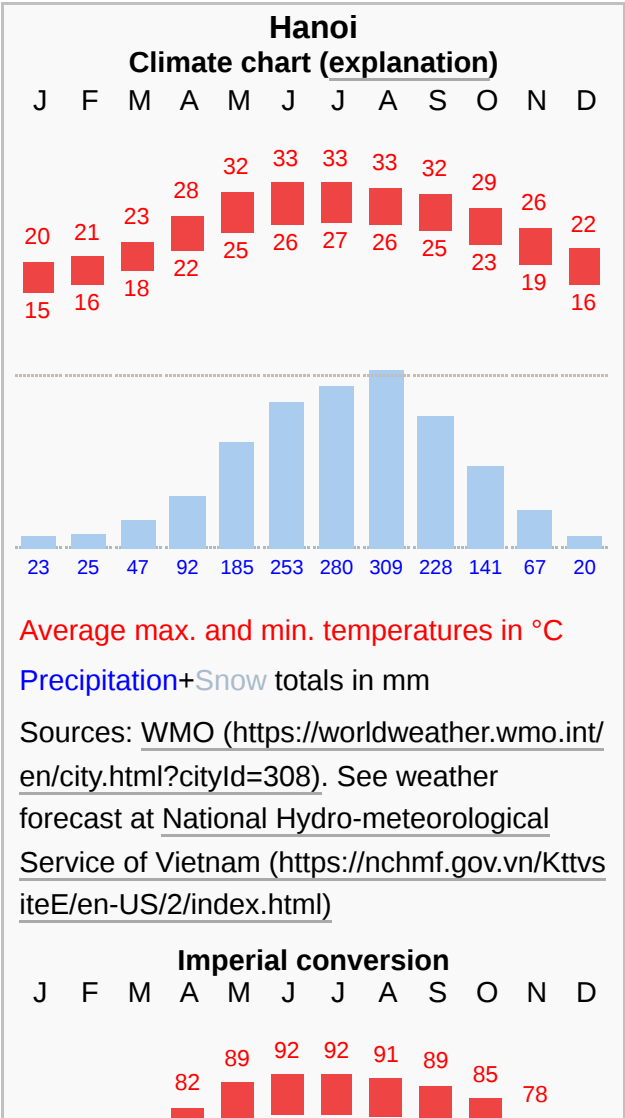
Climate

The Tết holiday (Lunar New Year) usually falls between late January and 20 February. In 2026 it will span 9 days, from Feb 14th to 22nd.

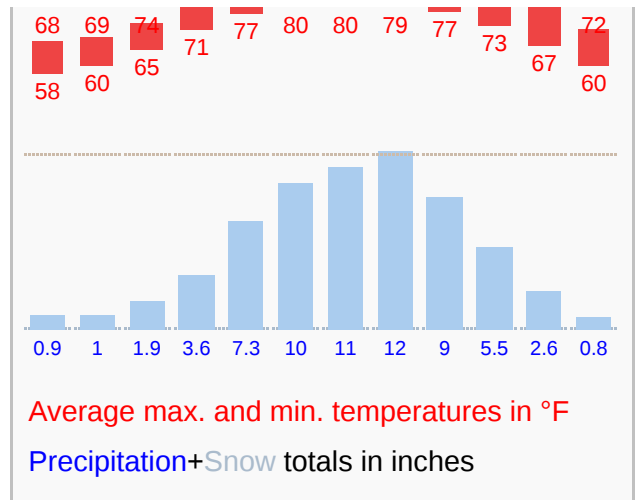
In spring, flowers are most beautiful during this time of the year. The weather warms up, with occasional light rain during the week. Locals believe that these light rains bring prosperity and luck in the new year.

Summer, on the other hand, borders on intolerable. The heat alone would be alright, but it's coupled with oppressive humidity and frequent rainstorms. At this time, visitors should be wary of mosquitoes as they abound. Hanoi has a perfect climate for the proliferation of insects.

In autumn, the weather is at its most perfect, with less humidity in the air. The temperature drops, allowing people a chance to flaunt their sweaters and jackets. Milkwood trees ("*cây hoa sũa*"), which only flowers in autumn, commonly lines many streets. The flower has a very distinct scent; if you visit Hanoi during the fall, ask locals about this tree and where you might sniff its distinct aroma.



Winter can be uncomfortable because it's not only cold, but also frequently humid. Winter in Hanoi feels even colder than it is because Vietnamese houses lack central heating; most houses have no heating at all. However, the winter months of December and January are still the driest months of the year with comparatively less rainfall, with the rains gradually picking up from the middle of February onwards. Pollution is unfortunately worst in winter, thanks to rampant waste burning, seasonal lack of rainfall, and the surrounding mountains trapping dirty air in the low-lying capital - Hanoi has frequently ranked among the top 5 most-polluted cities in the world in the past few years.



Get in

By plane

- 1 Nội Bài International Airport (<https://noibaiairport.vn/en>) (HAN ^{IATA})** (35 km north of the city center), ☎ +84 1900 636535. You can transfer through Nội Bài to other international destinations without a visa as long as you do not leave the terminal. International flights use Terminal 2, opened in 2015 and modern and spacious. There is a shuttle bus between the domestic and international terminals, or it can be walked in about 15-20 minutes. As of March 2025, Terminal 2 is undergoing large-scale expansion works; construction is planned to be finished by December 2025. (updated Mar 2025)



A list of some of the airlines that have a counter inside security at the Noi Bai International Airport

There are direct international flights from all major South East Asian capitals, most major Chinese, Taiwanese, South Korean and Japanese cities, and also from Bali, Sydney, Melbourne, Delhi, Mumbai, Dubai, Abu Dhabi, Doha, Istanbul, Munich, Frankfurt, Milan, Paris, and London. No direct flights from North America for now – Ho Chi Minh City, Taipei, Seoul or Tokyo will usually be the most convenient interchange. Domestic flights, by Vietnam Airlines (<http://vietnamairlines.com/>), Bamboo Airways (<http://www.bambooairways.com/>) and Vietjet Air (<https://www.vietjetair.com/>), serve Ho Chi Minh City, Da Nang, Hue, Nha Trang, Da Lat, Can Tho, Vinh, Dien Bien Phu, and Phu Quoc island.

Public and express buses depart from the arrivals level at the International Terminal, second road, at pillar 2 (turn left after exiting the terminal). From the Domestic Terminal they leave from between the Vietnam Airlines and Vietjet Air terminals.

- By express bus** — Bus 86 (<https://www.facebook.com/BusExpress86/>) (45,000 dong) runs 06:20–22:00 every 25 min and takes 45 min. It takes the expressway non-stop to the Tay Ho area, continuing limited stop to the Long Bien bus station, near the Old Quarter, the Opera House, Melia Hotel and the railway station. Towards the airport, buses run 05:05–21:40 from a booth at the south end of the main railway station.

- **By public bus** – Bus 07 (8,000 dong) runs 05:00–22:00 every 15 min and takes 60-90 min. It crosses the Thang Long Bridge and goes to the Daewoo Hotel in the west of Hanoi, from where it is 1 hr on foot to the Old Quarter of Hanoi. You might have to walk about 1 km west of the airport to catch bus 07 if it does not leave in front of the terminal.
- **By shuttle bus** – (It is not clear if these are still running as of June 2022.) Hourly between the airport and the **Vietnam Airlines Downtown Office (<https://vietnamairlines.com>)**, 25 Tràng Thi / 1 Quang Trung (*a bit south of the old quarter but conveniently stocked with taxis and motorbike drivers*), ☎ +84 24 3934-9660. Tickets at the airport are sold in the building in front of which the minibuses park, or you can give the fare directly to the driver. The cost is more for foreigners than for Vietnamese (which includes ethnic Vietnamese from overseas) for insurance reasons. The prices are indicated on the sticker fixed to the bus's body. The driver may give you trouble if you have additional bags, but if you push, you will get the same rate.
- **By taxi** – There are taxi stands just outside arrivals; turn right from the Domestic Terminal (T1), or left from International (T2). Avoid the touts in the arrival and just head straight for the taxi stand; the taxis they will try to get you in are most likely illegal, and you are likely to get ripped off. Official taxis are provided by various taxi companies, and all should run on the meter; **Mai Linh** and **Taxi Group** are generally the safest taxi companies to use. Have the address you want to go to ready and written down in Vietnamese — the chances of you speaking it in a way the driver will understand are slim. Maybe print out a map beforehand, since every street in Hanoi has clearly visible street signs at both ends, you should be able to discern which street you are in. A ride into the Old Quarter should cost 300,000–350,000 dong (Mai Linh taxi, July 2015) and come up somewhere around 27-28 km in distance on the meter. The French Quarter or south side of Hoan Kiem lake might be a little more, but still under 400,000 dong. Many taxis, including **Taxi Group (<https://taxigroup.com.vn/>)** and **ABC**, accept credit cards — ask first and show them the credit card. You might also get offered a fixed price of US\$20 by the driver, which works out as about a 25% premium. Some drivers will ask something like 800,000 dong, especially if they see 3-4 foreigners — just ignore them. Make sure that the meter starts shortly after the taxi moves off, and if you want to be sure the meter's not running fast, then from the International Terminal it should have reached about 0.7 km by the time you reach the airport toll booths (taxis don't pay the toll), and around 2 km by the time you pass the Domestic Terminal (the distance will be displayed in km, often along with the speed). A ride into the city should take about 30-40 minutes on the new highway depending on traffic. Downloading Grab app (local Uber) helps a lot. Fares around 300,000 dong to the city center, depending on demand, or about half of that by motorcycle, if you feel adventurous and only have a backpack.
- **By transfer** – If you already have a hotel booked, you might ask the hotel to dispatch a driver. The nicer hotels will do this and put the steep fare on your room bill.

By train

Domestic trains

The **Reunification Express** goes all the way to Ho Chi Minh City ("Saigon"), although there is very little 'express' about it. There are ten trains a day from HCMC taking 31-38 hours, but five of them are slow and are overtaken by faster trains — only use them for destinations north of Da Nang.

There are also train services to the northwest (including Lao Cai, from which you reach Sapa). To board trains bound for these destinations, you have to enter the railway station compound through the "backdoor" at **Tran Quy Cap station**.

In high season, buy your tickets as early as possible, especially since sleeper tickets can be sold out several days in advance. If you can't get a ticket anymore, try a travel agent who still might have stock. You may also try your luck in the station just before boarding time — agents still holding tickets will be eager to sell as the departure draws near. Nevertheless, travel agencies in Hanoi are known for their bad business practices. Some of them will try to overcharge you up to 300%, so it is better go to the train station by yourself and find out about the prices before you agree on any deal.

Tickets for all destinations are sold online at **Vietnam Railways** (<https://dsvn.vn/#/timve>), or at main stations. There have been reports of scams against tourists within and around the train station, so be wary of people trying to help you book. It's often better to buy tickets online or directly at the ticket counter.

Most trains use the main Hanoi train station for daily services from cities in the south including Hue and Nha Trang, while a few trains from northern cities as well as the international train from China terminates at Gia Lâm railway station.

- **2 Hanoi railway station** (Ga Hà Nội), Ga Hàng Cỏ, 120 Lê Duẩn St., ☎ [+84 24 3825-3949](tel:+842438253949). (updated May 2025)
- **3 Gia Lâm railway station** (Ga Gia Lâm), Phường Gia Thụy (5 km northeast of Hanoi downtown). (updated May 2025)

International trains

There is an overnight service from Nanning at 18:05 Chinese time via Pingxiang and Đồng Đăng. Tickets are sold at Nanning station, Guilin North station, Chongzuo station and Pingxiang station.

See Ho Chi Minh City to Shanghai overland if you're interested in crossing over to China by train.

By bus

Domestic buses

Long distance bus journeys within Vietnam can be planned using **VeXeRe.com** (<https://vexere.com/en-US>) and its app. Long distance buses arrive at My Dinh bus station (Bến Xe Mỹ Đình) and many other places depending on the bus company.

Public buses from southern destinations (e.g., Ninh Binh, 2 hr, 70,000 dong) arrive at Giap Bat bus station. To get from the Giap Bat bus station to the old quarter and Hoan Kiem Lake, leave aside all the hassle of taxi and motorbike drivers and take public Bus 8 towards Đông Mỹ (7,000 dong, pay on the bus). To find it head towards the main road inside Giap Bat station, you will see signs with numbers indicating the stops of different bus lines.

Most of the "open-tour" bus itineraries either begin or end in Hanoi, with Hue the next (or previous) stop (12-14 hr), and from there to Hoi An, Nha Trang, Dalat, Mui Ne, Ho Chi Minh City, and other cities in Vietnam, depending on the bus company. Most seem to stop at their office which could be right next to the old district and most backpacker hotels. Check when booking tickets.

International buses

Many companies sell tickets to Vientiane and Savannakhet in Laos. Do some research before you buy a ticket, as rattle-trap scam buses abound on this route.

Apec Travel runs several daily buses from Nanning in China to its office at 55 Trần Khát Chân St., on the south side of Hanoi's city center. Journey time is around 8 hours, including a change of bus and the usual formalities at the border.

See Ho Chi Minh City to Shanghai overland if you're interested in crossing over to China by bus.

Get around

Getting around Hanoi can be a challenge: traffic slows to a crawl for most of the day, and the public transport system has not kept up with the city's explosive growth.

By train

Metro Line 2A connects Cát Linh (west of the Old Quarter) to Yên Nghĩa in the southwestern suburbs. Metro Line 3 connects Cầu Giấy to Nhổn in the northwestern suburbs. The lines are not connected but this will change when the underground stretch between Cầu Giấy and Hanoi Station opens around 2027. Metro Line 2A is useful for getting to Vincom Mega Mall Royal City, one of Hanoi's largest shopping malls, which is within walking distance of Thượng Đình station.



Hanoi Metro Line 2A



By bus

Scam-free, cheap but a bit difficult to comprehend at first, the **buses** in Hanoi are relatively fast, air-conditioned and surprisingly comfortable.

Find your way:

- Download the **BusMap Hà Nội** mobile app (Google Play (<https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.t7.busmaphn>), Apple Store (<https://apps.apple.com/us/app/busmap-h%C3%A0-n%E1%BB%99i/id6447824891>)) for directions and live time estimates (not very accurate).
- Pick up a **physical map** with printed bus lines at the Trang Tien street (the book street by the Opera house).

Find your bus stop (there are usually blue signs) and wait for the bus to arrive. Go and sit in the bus, the bus assistant will come to you. The fare varies between 7,000 dong and 12,000 dong (price is fixed and depends on the line) (as of 2026). If necessary, they should have enough cash for change (but it might be better to avoid paying with larger bills). If you are unfamiliar with the city, make sure to inform the mostly helpful conductor where you want to get off. Or, use your phone's GPS and Google Maps to track your location. Keep in mind that traffic jams make schedules unreliable.

By taxi

The easiest way to get around is by using the Grab app (Android, iOS). The English user interface makes navigation a cinch, fares are fixed and typically cheaper, and you can pay by cash or credit card.

By metered taxi

Taxis proper are small cars seating 4 or larger cars seating 7. Within the city, three companies are generally reliable: *CP Taxi* and *Hanoi Taxi* are two brands of *Taxi Group*, in white cars, and *Mai Linh* are in green cars. *Taxi Nội Bài* specialise in airport transfers.

Your hotel will call a reliable firm, and leave them in no doubt where they are supposed to be taking you.

Unless you ordered by app, use the meter, flag-fall will be 20,000 dong for the first 2 km. Tips are not expected, but they are appreciated.

Good-spirited haggling, and a bit of language confusion, are part of the experience. Scams are more serious: these include crooked meters, roundabout routes, stealing part of your luggage and outright robbery. And even the nicest driver somehow never has change for your big bill: always hoard small bills.

By motorbike taxi

Motorbike taxis can be found on virtually every corner, especially in the Old Quarter: don't look for them, they'll accost you, so show only faint interest at first. You *must* haggle and firmly fix a fare in advance. Always write down the fare (with all the zeroes) and get an unequivocal "okay" from the driver. A 10-min ride (say from Hoan Kiem lake to Ho Chi Minh's tomb) should not exceed 20,000 dong; US dollars are often accepted. The driver has a second helmet for you.

Common scams here include (when you re-emerge from the tomb in reverent thought) claiming that you'd asked him to wait, that'll be two million dong please.

By cyclo taxi

Negotiate first or avoid using the cyclo services. At the end of the journey, a few men will come over to translate, and they will pretend to help and later insist that you pay the demanded amount.

By car

Hanoi's traffic is extremely chaotic, with seemingly perpetual traffic jams, and a large number of almost suicidal motorcyclists, cyclists and pedestrians. Vietnamese drivers are among the most aggressive in the world, and lanes are effectively non-existent. As such, driving yourself around is not recommended, and you should leave your transportation needs in the hands of professionals.

By motorbike

See also: [Vietnam by motorcycle](#)

Motorcycles can be rented for around US\$6–7 a day, and can be arranged by most hotels. This is good for making lots of trips around the city for individuals or duos, but be careful: Hanoi traffic is very difficult place to sharpen motorbike skills. Park on the pavement with other bikes, and be sure to lock the front

wheel. Locals will help arrange the bikes near their stores. Many shops that have bike attendants will give you a ticket in exchange for parking your bike. This may or may not come with a fee. The ticket will either have your license plate number written on it, or the ticket itself will be numbered, with that number subsequently chalked somewhere on your bike. In such cases, where you've been given a ticket, the attendants may ask that you not lock the steering column or front wheel of your bike so that they can rearrange the bikes as customers come and go. Keep your ticket—it is not heard of that people try to charge tourists twice. If you intend to go further out of the city, you may want to conceal this fact when renting the motorbike. Out-of-city rentals can be up to twice as expensive as the in-city charge, even if you rent longer since it takes you longer.

By foot

This is the best way to traverse the maze of little streets in the old quarter and Hoan Kiem lakeside (which is traffic-free at weekends). From there it's a 1.5-km stroll to the Ho Chi Minh complex, 2 km to West Lake; follow usual local rules on traffic safety.

Of the two bridges across the Red River, the southern (Chương Dương) is for vehicles only and has no sidewalk. The northern (Long Biên) is for trains, bikes, motorbikes and pedestrians. This impressive century-old structure is almost 2 km long, and also serves a river islet of small plantations. It was a frequent target of bombing runs during the America-Vietnam War, but was rapidly repaired each time, becoming a national symbol of resilience. It is now a rusting hulk that would have been replaced long ago if not for its historical significance; the sidewalks are composed of thin concrete plates with slits that one can see the river below through. Walking across is not for the faint of heart.

See

Museums

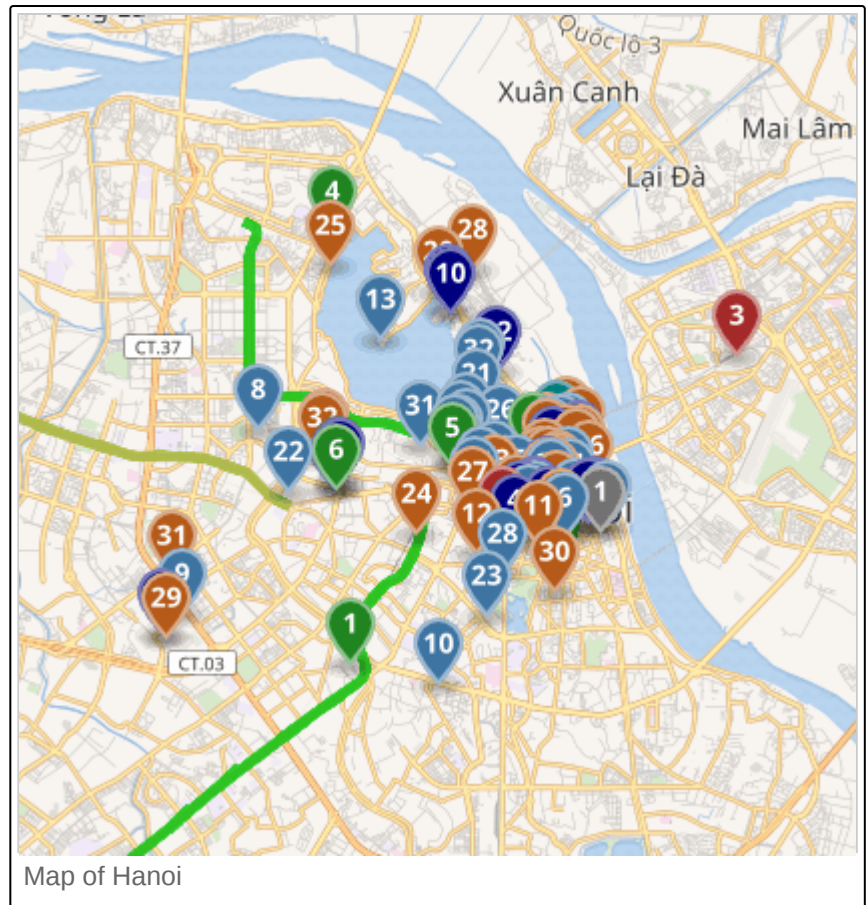
Near the city center

- **1 Fine Arts Museum (<https://vnfam.vn/en/>)** (Bảo Tàng Mỹ Thuật), 66 Nguyen Thai Hoc St (*opposite Temple of Literature*), ☎ +84 24 3733-2131. Daily 08:30-17:00. Only party-approved art is shown here with information in English and Vietnamese. On three floors of a colonial building, with another three galleries in the west wing. Pieces include soldiers on boats depicted on prehistoric bronze drums, Buddhist art, and revolutionary art of the 20th century wars. Also some interesting lacquer and silk paintings. Adult 40,000 dong. (updated Aug 2025)
- **2 Hồ Chí Minh Mausoleum.** Tu-Th 06:30–10:30 Sa Su 07:30-11:30. The city down south may have his name, but only Hanoi has the man himself, entombed in distinctly Lenin-esque fashion. Against his wishes, but that's how it goes. No talking, revealing clothing (shorts should be knee length and no exposed shoulders), or other signs of disrespect allowed while viewing; photos are allowed only from outside, in the grand Ba Dinh Square. Purses are allowed into the tomb, but expect them to be searched by several bored soldiers along the way. Left luggage is handled in a complicated scheme: there is an office near the street for large bags, with separate windows for Vietnamese and foreigners, and a further office for cameras, which will be transported to a *third* office right outside the exit of the mausoleum.

Items checked in at the first office, however, will stay there. The mausoleum is closed for a couple months around the end of the year, when the body is taken abroad for maintenance. It is closed in the afternoons for maintenance. Free. (updated Aug 2025)

■ **3 Hồ Chí Minh Museum, 19**

Ngoc Ha St, Ba Dinh, ☎ +84 24 3846-3572, bthochiminh@hn.vnn.vn (mailto:bthochiminh@hn.vnn.vn). Daily 08:00-11:30, and Tu-Th Sa Su 14:00-16:00. This gleaming white museum and its gloriously ham-handed iconography is the perfect chaser to the solemnity of the mausoleum. The building, completed in 1990, is intended to evoke a white lotus. Some photos and old letters are on display on the second floor, but the main exhibition space is on the third floor. It includes cars crashing through walls to represent the chaos of post-war American capitalism, soldiers charging around with bombs that looked like electric plugs, a cave hideout re-imagined as the inside of Ho Chi Minh's brain, and several other postmodern confections integrated with the detailed main story of the man's life and his country's struggle. There are plenty of photographs, prison documents and newspaper cuttings tracing his life along the way. The tour ends with a burnt bridge signifying the separation of Vietnam, followed by a reconstructed bridge showing the unification of Vietnam after the war. One of the more informative museums in Vietnam. Free guides are available in English, French, Chinese and Russian. The displays are labelled in English and French. 40,000 dong. (updated May 2017)



The Presidential Palace, formerly home to the Governors-General of French Indochina

- **4 Hồ Chí Minh's Vestige in the Presidential Palace Area, 1 Bach Thao, Ba Dinh, ☎ +84 4 0804 4529.** Summer 07:30-11:00, 14:00-16:00; Winter 08:00-11:00, 13:30-16:00, closed M F afternoons. The exit from the mausoleum takes you right into the grounds of the, uh, vestige, where Ho Chi Minh lived and worked from 1954 until his death in 1969. The nicely landscaped complex includes Ho Chi Minh's two homes (one a small one-story house, the other a traditional stilt house), kept shiny and "as he left them" by the authorities, as well as a garage with two of Ho's presidential cars and a carp-filled pond. You also get to see Ho Chi Minh's work room and Politburo meeting room. The Presidential Palace is nearby, but it's not open to visitors. Pamphlets are available in English, Chinese, French and Korean. Guided tours are usually available if you wait. 40,000 dong. (updated May 2017)

■ **5 National Museum of Vietnamese History (<http://www.baotanglichsu.vn/subportal/>)** (Bảo tàng

Cách mạng Việt Nam), No 1 Trang Tien Street and 216 Tran Quang Khai Street. Daily 08:00-12:00 and 13:30-17:00, except first Monday of month. Actually two museums: one covers Vietnam from prehistoric times to 1945 and the other covers 1945 to present. This museum gives a very informed and detailed account of the Vietnamese struggle against first the French (starting in 1858—on the first floor), then against the US, ending on 30 Apr 1975 (on the ground floor). It is housed in a colonial French building which was completed in 1932. The building, designed by the architect Ernest Hébrard is considered as a successful blend between the colonial French architecture and traditional Vietnamese architecture, called Indochina architecture. He created double-walls and balconies for a natural ventilation system and protection from sunshine. 40,000 dong for both. (updated Aug 2018)



The Flag Tower of Hanoi

- **6 Vietnamese Women's Museum (<http://www.baotangphunu.org.vn/>)** (Bảo Tàng Phụ nữ Việt Nam), 36 Ly Thuong Kiet St, Hoan Kiem District (*Central Hanoi, 1 km S of Hoan Kiem Lake*), ☎ +84 24 3825-9938, fax: +84 24 3825-9129, info@baotangphunu.org.vn (mailto:info@baotangphunu.org.vn). Daily 08:00-17:00. This often overlooked museum has benefited from an extensive renovation of its permanent exhibitions. The modernised interior is well laid out with information in Vietnamese, English and French, and contains a huge amount of information on the fearsome female heroines of Vietnamese history. There are also exhibitions on the rituals and traditions surrounding women in family, as well as a beautifully presented collection of intricate hand-made ethnic costumes. A highlight is the regularly updated special exhibitions on a diverse range of subjects, from contemporary issues such as single mothers and street vendors to traditional medicine and Mother Goddess worship. English language tours are available on request. 40,000 dong (80,000 dong with audioguide). (updated Feb 2025)

Further out

- **7 Vietnam Military History Museum (<http://baotanglichsuquansu.vn/en-gb/>)** (Bảo tàng Lịch sử Quân sự Việt Nam), Km6+500, CT03, Tây Mỗ Ward, Nam Từ Liêm Dist, ☎ +84 24 6253 1367. Tu-Th Sa Su 08:00-11:30 & 13:00-16:30; closed M F. Originally a modest museum located next to the Flag Tower, the Military History Museum and all its 150,000 artifacts has been relocated in 2024 to an enormous 39-hectare compound in the city's outskirts, 12 km from its original location. Now the largest and most modern museum in all of Vietnam, the imposing main building covers the country's military history extending back some two millennia. All museum exhibits and videos are captioned in Vietnamese and English. The vast courtyard houses dozens of military vehicles, aircraft and artillery; many of which are French, American and South Vietnamese assets captured in the Indochina wars. Extremely popular with locals, the museum is usually completely packed on weekends, with dozens of tour buses ferrying out-of-town visitors to the site. Peak queuing times can exceed an hour as a result, so try to visit early on a weekday if possible; give the museum a call beforehand to check how busy it is. Entry fee 40,000 dong; free for under-



The newly-relocated Military History Museum

16s, over-80s, soldiers, veterans, military academy cadets and contributors to the Revolution. (updated May 2025)

- **8 Museum of Ethnology (<http://www.vme.org.vn/>)** (Bảo tàng Dân tộc học Việt Nam), Nguyen Van Huyen St, Cau Giay District (*Bus 14 from Hoan Kiem Lake - ask the conductor when to stop, and take a 500 m walk towards the museum (backtrack a little from the bus stop, and when you see a large street perpendicular to the street that you dropped off, take that street and walk down the street until you see the Museum of Ethnology to your left).* Bus 38 goes from right outside the Temple of Literature to the street the museum is on). Tu-Su 08:30-17:30. Exhibitions cover mainly the culture and ritual practices of the various ethnic groups in the whole of Vietnam. One of the key attractions of the museum is the open-air exhibition, which has reconstructions of traditional houses from multiple ethnic groups, which even comes with inhabitants in costumes. The museum features actual explanations of the exhibits in Vietnamese, French and English. There is an excellent café on the premises. 40,000 dong for foreigners, extra 50,000 dong for photography.. (updated Aug 2018)
- **9 Hanoi Museum** (Bảo tàng Hà Nội), Pham Hung St, Cau Giay District. Tu-Su 08:00-11:30 & 13:30-17:00. Local natural and human history down the ages. Free. (updated Jan 2019)
- **10 Air Force Museum** (Bảo Tàng Không Quân), Truong Chinh St (SW of city centre). There's a UH-1 helicopter, Soviet-built MiG fighters, a huge Mi-6 helicopter and other aircraft. Unfortunately they've been exposed to the elements for some time and local children climb over them.

Parks

- **11 Hoàn Kiếm Lake.** A pleasant park in the centre of town, an easy walk from anywhere in the Old Quarter. This is the locals' favorite leisure spot; especially during weekends, when the lakeside streets are closed to traffic and becomes a pedestrian-only area. A great place to watch people practising *tai chi* in the morning or to sit and read in the afternoon. At weekends the park becomes even more popular as the normally busy road around it is pedestrianised, and instead filled with children driving electric cars or riding hoverboards. *Hoàn Kiếm* means "returned sword", and the name comes from a legend in which King Lê Lợi was given a magical sword by the gods, which he used to drive out the invading Chinese. Later, while boating on the lake, he encountered a giant turtle, which grabbed the sword and carried it down to its depths, returning it to the gods from whom it had come. (You can see a version of the legend at the Water Puppet Theatre.) The giant soft-shell turtles, whom Vietnamese biologists assigned to a separate species, *Rafetus leloii*, resided in the lake until the early 21st century. One of them, who died in 1968, has been preserved by the wonders of taxidermy, and can be viewed in a glass box (sarcophagus?) in a pavilion adjacent to Ngọc Sơn Temple on the island in the lake. Park is free; 30,000 dong admission to the island temple (玉山祠).. (updated Mar 2025)
- **12 Lý Thái Tổ Statue & Park** (SE corner of lake). The park faces Hoàn Kiếm lake, with a beautiful view of the busy Hang Bai St. and the serenity of the willows on the bank of the lake. Many locals view this mini-park as their favourite place because it is a symbol of the integration of modernity and tradition. One might encounter a group of youths practising hip-hop, breakdancing, or playing foot-badminton, while at the same time seeing a three-generation family enjoying a walk in the park. (updated May 2017)
- **13 Hồ Tây** (West Lake) (NW of the city). Mostly a residential hub of the well-to-do. The InterContinental West Lake, Sheraton Hanoi and Pan Pacific Hanoi are on this lake front.
- **14 Lenin Statue & Park** (Dien Bien Phu St, across from the Army Museum). You can always feel the diversity and liveliness of Hanoi here. In the morning, there are low-energy aerobics class for elders and aerobics class for the young. During the day, one can enjoy the

tranquility in the park since everybody is either at work or in school. In the afternoon, it becomes a playground for children, students, soccer teams, and badminton players.

Temples

- **15 One-Pillar Pagoda** (*tucked away between the Ho Chi Minh Mausoleum and Museum*). Visitors find this either charming and lovely or utterly pointless, depending on how many tour groups are crammed into the small grounds at the time of their visit. It has a long history attached to it. Regarded as one of Vietnam's iconic temples, it was built by Emperor Lý Thái Tông. The emperor was childless and dreamt that he met the bodhisattva Avalokiteshvara, who handed him a baby son while seated on a lotus flower. He then married a peasant girl that he had met and she bore him a son. The emperor constructed the temple in gratitude for this in 1049 having been told by a monk to build the temple, by erecting a pillar in the middle of a lotus pond, similar to the one he saw in the dream. Before the pagoda was opened, prayers were held for the longevity of the monarch. The temple is built of wood on a single stone pillar 1.25 m in diameter, and it is designed to resemble a lotus blossom, which is a Buddhist symbol of purity, since a lotus blossoms in a muddy pond. In 1954, the French Union forces destroyed the pagoda before withdrawing from Vietnam after the First Indochina War, it was rebuilt afterwards. Free. (updated May 2017)
- **16 Ngọc Sơn Temple** (玉山寺). Located on a small island in the Hoan Kiem Lake, connected with the mainland by a bridge. With small but attractive grounds, the temple displays on Vietnamese history and, more memorably, displays on the giant turtles, including a mummified specimen (who died in 1968). The two on-site gift shops vend a variety of souvenirs, many of them turtle-themed. Entry fee: 50.000 Dong (updated Jan 2025)
- **17 Temple of Literature** (<http://vanmieu.gov.vn/vi/>) (Văn Miếu / 文庙), Quốc Tử Giám St (*a few blocks south of the Ho Chi Minh mausoleum*). Daily 08:00-18:00. The Temple was founded in 1070 and became the country's first university six years later. The overall design is somewhat similar to the "original" Confucian Temple in Qufu, with 5 courtyards. Most of the architecture is named with titles indicating reverence to literature and language. The showpiece of the complex is the third courtyard with eighty-odd stone tablets, each mounted on the back of a tortoise (known as *bixi* in Chinese), inscribed with the names of graduates. Another courtyard is full of gift shops, which also sell stamps, coins, and books. A reduced-size replica of the famous giant softshell turtle (the original being at the Ngọc Sơn Temple at the Lake of the Returned Sword) can be seen in one of the pavilions as well; it was made by Vietnamese artisans out of ceramic, and gold-plated. The fourth courtyard contains a temple and statues devoted to Confucius and his four disciples. Chinese history buffs should look out for the 萬世師表 plaque, which was presented to the temple by Emperor Kangxi of China in 1693. The fifth and last courtyard, which was destroyed by the French in 1946 and rebuilt in 2000, contains a mini-museum showcasing information on Emperor Lý Thánh Tông and his successors who built and renovated the temple. You may find a Vietnamese band



Hoan Kiem lake in the city center



Temple of Literature



playing local instrumental music in front of this museum. There are explanatory wall-hangings in English and French all along the way, and you don't need a guide. Adult 30,000 dong; student, senior or disabled person 15,000 dong; child under 15 free. (updated Apr 2020)

- **18 Quán Sứ Pagoda (<https://chuaquansu.org/>)** (Chùa Quán Sứ), 73 P. Quán Sứ. Daily 07:30-11:30, 13:30-17:30. The headquarters of Vietnamese Buddhism. (updated Jan 2024)
- **19 Trấn Quốc Pagoda** (Chùa Trấn Quốc), 46 Đ. Thanh Niên, Trúc Bạch, Tây Hồ. The oldest Buddhist temple in Hanoi, on an island near the southeastern shore of West Lake. (updated Jan 2024)

Four Sacred Temples

The Four Sacred Temples (Thăng Long Tứ Trấn) were built at the four cardinal points of the Imperial City of Thăng Long to guard it from evil spirits. Although most of the city wall is long gone, all four temples survive to this day.

- **20 Bạch Mã Temple** (Đền Bạch Mã), 76 Hang Buom St, Hoan Kiem District. The eastern temple, dedicated to Long Đỗ, the thành hoàng (city god) of Thăng Long (now Hà Nội), and represented in the temple as a white horse (Bạch Mã in Vietnamese, hence its name).
- **21 Quán Thánh Temple** (Đền Quán Thánh), Đ. Thanh Niên, Quán Thánh, Ba Đình. The northern temple, dedicated to the Taoist god Xuanwu, known in Vietnamese as Trấn Vũ, with a large bronze statue of him at the main altar.
- **22 Voi Phục Temple** (Đền Voi Phục), 306B Kim Ma St, Ngọc Khanh Ward, Ba Đình District. The western temple, dedicated to Prince Linh Lang, a son of King Lý Thái Tông and his 9th concubine Dương Thị Quang, who was killed in action at the Battle of Như Nguyệt River in a war with China's Song Dynasty. The name Voi Phục means "kneeling elephant", and you can see two statues of elephants in a kneeling position at the front of the temple, hence its name.
- **23 Kim Liên Shrine** (Đền Kim Liên), 148 P. Kim Hoa, Phương Liên, Đống Đa. The southern temple, dedicated to Cao Sơn Đại Vương, a Vietnamese mountain god who is said to be a son of King Lạc Long Quân of the ancient Hồng Bàng dynasty and his wife, the immortal mountain snow goddess Âu Cơ.

Chinese assembly halls

While Hanoi no longer has a Chinatown, as most of the ethnic Chinese community was expelled to China in the wake of the 1979 Sino-Vietnamese War, two Chinese assembly halls remain in the former Chinatown area as a reminder of that lost community. They had been converted into schools for local children and long been hidden behind unsightly walls and fences, but were painstakingly restored to their former glory in the 2010s.

- **24 Fujian Assembly Hall** (Hội Quán Phúc Kiến / 福建會館), 40 P. Lãn Ông. Former assembly hall of the Chinese from Fujian province. It was converted to a primary school after the 1979 Sino-Vietnamese War, but was restored to its former glory in 2015, and is used for some public functions.
- **25 Canton Assembly Hall** (Hội Quán Quảng Đông / 粵東會館), 22 P. Hàng Buồm. Former assembly hall of the Chinese from Guangdong province. It was converted to a kindergarten after the 1979 Sino-Vietnamese War, but was restored to its former glory in 2021, and is now an exhibition space open to the public.

Miscellaneous

- **26 Hanoi Citadel.** Built as a residence for the Vietnamese king, the citadel was mostly destroyed by the French, used as a military headquarters during the Vietnam War. It is now a  [UNESCO World Heritage Site](#) as "Central Sector of the Imperial Citadel of Thang Long - Hanoi".
- **Hanoi Train Street.** Buildings press up nearly to the railroad ties of the railway through central Hanoi, creating a narrow corridor for trains to pass through. Two stretches of rail corridor, just to the north and the south of Hanoi Station, are lined by restaurants and cafes. Several times a day, trains quickly pass close to the cafe seating. You'll have to buy a coffee, juice or a beer, but prices are reasonable. Safety concerns prompt occasional closures.
 - **27 Hanoi Train Street (North),** 5 Trần Phú, Hàng Bông, Hoàn Kiếm. Because of stupid tourists posing for selfies in front of oncoming trains, there are now police posted at the entrance to order people away. Cafe owners can bring you in through passageways nearby, however, so wander around to look for an invitation. Trains pass around 15:00 and 19:00 daily. (updated Apr 2025)
 - **28 Hanoi Train Street (South),** Ng. 222 Đ.Lê Duẩn, Khâm Thiên, Đống Đa (*between Khâm Thiên and Ng. 222 Đ.Lê Duẩn*). Trains pass several times daily, typically around 10:30, 15:00, and 19:00. (updated Apr 2025)
- **29 St. Joseph's Cathedral (<https://www.tonggiaophanhanoi.org/>),** Nha Tho, Hoàn Kiếm District. M-Sa 08:00-11:00, 14:00-17:00; Su 07:00-10:30, 15:00-21:00. A late 19th-century Gothic Revival church that serves as the cathedral of the Roman Catholic Archdiocese of Hanoi. Built by the French in 1886, the exterior is gaunt and grey, but the interior is light and peaceful. Mass is held several times a day, and for Sunday evening mass at 18:00 the crowds are huge: the service is broadcast to those outside who can't get in. Major renovation works to maintain the cathedral's structural integrity and restore its exterior paintwork were completed in 2022. (updated Mar 2025)
- **30 Presidential Palace,** 2 Hùng Vương, Ngọc Hồ, Ba Đình. Completed in 1906 as the residence of the French Governor-General of Indochina. It became the official residence of the President of North Vietnam following independence in 1954, and later of the President of Vietnam following reunification in 1975. Ho Chi Minh was said to have refused to live in the palace for symbolic reasons, though he used it to receive state guests. The building is not open to the public, but you can view it from the outside and take photographs.

Wartime sites

- **31 B-52 Lake** (Huu Tiep Lake), Ngoc Ha Precinct, Ba Dinh District. Until 19 Dec 1972, this was just a small brackish pond just off Hoàng Hoa Thám St., about 1 km west of the mausoleum. On that day, in a twisted retelling of the Hoan Kiem legend, Vietnamese anti-aircraft missiles blasted the enemy's eight-engine, 100-ton aircraft and sent it to the shallow bottom of the lake, where it remains.
- **32 Downed Aircraft Memorial** (*Along Thanh Nien St on Truc Bach Lake*). A stone plaque commemorating the shooting down of a US Navy (not "USAF" as depicted) aircraft in 1967. Read the Vietnamese script and you can pick out the name of *John McCain*, the late U.S. senator, one of the airmen.
- **33 Hỏa Lò Prison** (Hanoi Hilton), 1 Hỏa Lò, Hoan Kiem. Daily 08:30-12:00, 14:00-16:30 (M & F from 08:00). This prison was built by the French at the turn of the 20th century, in classical French prison design. Two thirds of the prison was torn down to make way for the

Hanoi Towers, and the rest was converted into a museum. This is where the French imprisoned and executed Vietnamese freedom fighters. The museum exhibits the plight of jailed political revolutionaries under the French colonial regime and the struggle of the Vietnamese people against imperialism in chilling detail. Later, during the America-Vietnam War, the prison held US prisoners of war that sarcastically referred to it as the "Hanoi Hilton". This period is not emphasized, except to present the official narrative of how humanely the POWs were treated, such as showing photos only of prisoners being treated well and playing basketball and playing chess. The museum claims to have the flight suit of John McCain, the most notable POW held here, from when his plane was shot down. Most of the exhibits have detailed English information, but you can also get an audioguide for 50,000 dong. 50,000 dong.



John McCain shot down, Truc Bach lake, Hanoi



Hoa Lo, "The Hanoi Hilton"

Do

- **Flavors of Hanoi** (<https://flavorsofhanoi.com/>), 25 Hang Be, Hoan Kiem, Hanoi, ☎ +84 967 258 586, ✉ hello@flavorsofhanoi.com. 09:00-21:00. A local foodie experiences provider, they offer personal street food tours to help visitors explore Hanoi's Old Quarter and French Quarter through their taste buds.

Cinemas

- **August Movie Theater** (Rap Thang 8) (*On Hang Bai St, 5 min away from Trang Tien Plaza and the commercial area, such as Pho Hue, Hai Ba Trung and Trang Tien St*). Renovated into a Nightclub (updated Jul 2024)
- **CGV Cinemas (formerly Megastar)** (<https://www.cgv.vn/en/theaters/cinema/index/city/vn-04/name/cgv-vincom-center-ba-trieu>), 191 Ba Trieu (*on the 6th floor of the Vincom City Towers*). The movies are relatively new, perhaps one or two months later than in the US. The movies are not dubbed although there are subtitles so both non-Vietnamese speakers and locals can enjoy them. 70,000-115,000 dong for 2D movies depending on day and time. 90,000-230,000 dong for 3D movies. (updated Mar 2017)

Cooking classes

- **EZ Cooking Class** (<http://www.daynauan.vn>), 49 Lane, 49 Huynh Thuc Khang St.
- **EDUMA** (<http://daynauan.info/>), 94 Lane, 49 Lo Duc St.
- **Hanoi Cooking Centre** (<http://hanoicookingcentre.com/>), 44 Chau Long St (*close to Truc Bac lake*), ☎ +84 24 3715-0088. Cooking school, retail outlet and beautiful courtyard cafe with an excellent menu of Asian and Western favourites. Hands-on cooking classes and short courses in a relaxed atmosphere.

- **Hidden Hanoi (<http://hiddenhanoi.vn/>)**, 137 Nghi Tam Rd (aka Duong An Duong Vuong), Tay Ho (*on the bund road in the Tay Ho District*), info@hiddenhanoi.com.vn (<mailto:info@hiddenhanoi.com.vn>). Hidden Hanoi runs walking tours and cooking classes. There are many options including the 1-hr walking tour of the local market, followed by the 3-hr cooking class. Cooking class menus change daily, and there are other walking tours available. They also run language classes, and there is a dance school in the same building.
- **Vietnam Culinary School**, hanoiculinaryclass@gmail.com (<mailto:hanoiculinaryclass@gmail.com>). Fully equipped facilities to learn Vietnamese cooking. A typical day will commence with a visit to the morning market accompanied by an instructor to select ingredients for your cooking lesson. The class will be followed by a meal in a restaurant sampling your own cooking as well as traditional Vietnamese dishes.
- **Học Viện Ẩm Thực (<http://www.hocvienamthuc.com/>)**, 60 Tran Nhan Tong. (updated Jan 2018)

Pampering

- **SF Salon and Spa**, 30 Cua Dong, Hoan Kiem, ☎ +84 24 3926-2032. Nice, not too expensive spa with a range of services, including massages, manicures/pedicures, facials. They will pay for your one-way taxi fare to the spa. Friendly staff.

Rock climbing

- **VietClimb (<http://vietclimb.vn/>)**, So 40 Ngo 76 An Duong, ☎ +84 914 548 903. Tu-Su 14:00-22:00. 200-m² climbing surface, a 50-m² café & terrace to chill out, and a climbing pro-shop. Also a great place for finding out where to climb immediately outside of Hanoi.

Theatre

- **Thang Long Water Puppet Theatre (<http://thanglongwaterpuppet.org>)**, 57 Dinh Tien Hoang St (*across from Hoan Kiem Lake*), ☎ +84 24 3824-9494, fax: +84 4 824 5117. Musicians accompany folk legends from Vietnamese history, told with wooden men, women, and dragons, dancing and splashing on the face of the water. The narratives are sung in Vietnamese, but lyrics are available in several languages. Or just ignore the dialogue and narration and focus on the special effects. There are several performances throughout the day. Don't worry about getting wet, but the seats are very small, and visitors with above-average height will have to squirm a bit. Camera passes are an extra 20,000 dong. (updated Nov 2016)
- **Hồng Hà Theater (Vietnam Tuồng Theatre)**, 51 Duong Thanh Street (inside Old Quarter) (*walk: from northern tip of Hoan Kiem Lake go along Hang gai street to the west about 500 m then turn right at Duong Thanh street, the theater is on the right at number 51; by bus: take bus 01 stop at bus stop 30 Duong Thanh then walk about 30 m toward the north*), ☎ +84 984 545 228, honghatheatre@gmail.com (<mailto:honghatheatre@gmail.com>). M Th 18:00-19:00. Hát tuồng (Hanoi: [há:t tũn]) or hát bội (Saigon: [há:k bôj]) is a form of Vietnamese theatre. Hát tuồng is often referred to as classical "Vietnamese opera" influenced by Chinese opera which combines acting, singing, and dancing. Tuồng employs the use of stock characters who are recognizable from their make-up and costumes, which are typically very elaborate and extravagant. Usually, a character's personalities can be revealed through three features: the color of the face, the eyebrows, and the beard. In this 1 hour show, the artists will perform most interesting, unique and typical recitals from famous Tuongs (which typically last 1-2 hours). The show starts at 18:00 but from 17:30 the

theater is open so the guests can interact with the artists, observe the performance preparation and try to sing, dance, play drum with the artists and enjoy traditional royal tea. The English leaflets will be provided for every guest which will introduce the content of each recital throughout the show. 150,000 dong. (updated Sep 2018)

- **Công Nhân Theater (<https://viettheatre.com/en>)** (Tu Phu (Four Palaces Show)), 42 Trang Tien street (*from the Opera House walk down Trang Tien street 1 block, the Theater is on the right; from southern side of Hoan Kiem lake, walk toward Trang Tien street for 2 blocks, the theater is on the left*), ☎ +84 902 195 650 (Vietnamese), +84 907 033 553 (English), ticket@viettheatre.com (<mailto:ticket@viettheatre.com>). Th Sa 18:00-18:45, 19:30-20:15. "Four Palaces" refers to the belief in the worship of Four Mother Goddesses, including Mother Goddess of Heaven, Mother Goddess of Forest, Mother Goddess of Water and Mother Goddess of Earth. The late 19th and early 20th centuries were the most flourishing periods of Mother Goddess religion in Viet folklore. There are times when Mother Goddess religion is considered as a manifestation of superstition and thus prohibited. However, the rituals of "Tứ Phủ" (Four Palaces), known by several other names, for instance, Tứ Phủ Công Đồng or Four Palaces Council, hát văn, châu thánh, etc., still have a remarkable presence and strong reflection in Viet folk arts for several reasons:
 1. Four Palaces is considered as a medium of lively communication of humans with Gods or Saints, divine beings who are familiar to Vietnamese both spiritually and in real life. The communications are organized as rituals by psychics or mediums who play roles of middlemen connecting people to divines. As such, it connected with Vietnamese in general.
 2. Four Palaces is a lively form of art which collected many materials of folk arts, for example, hát châu văn or châu thánh (a traditional folk art which combines trance singing and dancing) and rites (ceremonies) as well as music with drum, flute and folk instruments; ritual dancing, rites of hầu đồng (hiển thánh) or ritual dress of sorceresses, etc. You can buy ticket online via website. USD5.49-12.95. (updated Sep 2018)
- **Hanoi Chèo Theatre (<http://nhahatcheovietnam.vn/>)** (Show "Long Thanh Dien Xuong"), 1 Giang Văn Minh (*across street from Kim Son Pagoda*), ☎ +84 24 3845-7403. Th 17:30-18:30. Chèo (Vietnamese: [cêw]) is a form of generally satirical musical theatre, often encompassing dance, traditionally performed by Vietnamese peasants in northern Vietnam. It is usually performed outdoors by semi-amateur touring groups, stereotypically in a village square or the courtyard of a public building, although it is increasingly also performed indoors and by professional performers. Chèo stage art is one of the great cultural heritage of the Vietnamese folk treasure. Chèo has been a popular art form of the Vietnamese people for many generations and has fostered the national spirit through its lyrical content. Show Long Thanh Dien Xuong introduces to the visitors different types of folk arts/performance which used to be common in the history, when Hanoi was the royal capital of Viet Kingdom: cheo, ca tru, chau van, xam, water puppet. 150,000 dong. (updated Sep 2018)
- **1 Hanoi Opera House (<http://hanoioperahouse.org.vn/>)**, 01 Tràng Tiền, hnoopera@hanoioperahouse.org.vn (<mailto:hnoopera@hanoioperahouse.org.vn>). Built by the French during the colonial period, it usually hosts classical music concerts and local Vietnamese plays and pop concerts rather than operas.

Buy

Money

ATMs are everywhere — see Money on [Vietnam#Buy](#) for general information.

Money exchange can be done at jewellery shops, which usually offer better rates than banks. The most popular ones are located along Ha Trung Rd (5-min walk from Hoan Kiem Lake) and Hang Bac. Just walk into the shop and ask them if they change money. Ask 5 or more shops to see which one gives the best rate. Hotels also often provide currency exchange service, but at terrible rates. Don't exchange money with people in the street, as the risk of getting counterfeit notes from them is high.

Markets

- **Chợ Hôm** (The equivalent meaning in English would be "Evening Market"), Pho Hue. A huge range of goods, and famous for the fabric market on the second floor. There are many kiosks selling different types of fabrics ranging from cheap, affordable to best quality with a high price. When shopping, take your time and never rush into buying anything. Sellers often quote a very high price that you can bargain down considerably. (updated Jul 2024)
- **1 Chợ Đồng Xuân**. Famous for being the market for wholesalers. They have school supplies, stuffed animals, clothing. It is quite an experience to spend some time in the market observing the sellers and buyers. (updated Apr 2025)
- **Chợ Hàng Da**. A 6-storey building to house the market is under construction. All the kiosks are now in the neighbouring area, either on Phùng Hưng (second-hand clothing), Đường Thành, or Lý Nam Đế Streets. Sell a huge range of goods including pets, groceries, prepared foods and fabrics. It is now mostly empty. (updated Aug 2018)
- **Night Market**. Weekends from 19:00. The major north-south street in the Old Quarter, from Hoàn Kiếm Lake almost to the train overpass, becomes a crowded walking street with everything from pirated DVDs to traditional ornaments. Prices are negotiable, but "foreigner pricing" is fairly common. Thankfully many shops nowadays offer fixed prices with big "no bargaining" signs.

Bookstores

- **Bookworm Hanoi (<http://www.bookwormhanoi.com/>)**, 44 Chau Long (Hanoi Cooking Center), ☎ +84 24 3715-3711, +84 912 561 800. New and used books.
- Small Vietnamese bookstores (*nhà sách*) line Phố Đinh Lễ St, just south of the large post office east of Hoan Kiem Lake. Most of them stock a variety of bilingual dictionaries, but hardly any books in English. Among them, as of 2016, Nhà Sách Lam seemed to have the best selection of maps (both Hanoi City and Vietnam regional).
- Most of the numerous souvenir shops inside the Temple of Literature (see under Museums; admission fee needs to be paid to get in) also carry a selection of books about Vietnam in English and other foreign languages (French, Spanish, Japanese), as well as culture- and history-oriented books in Vietnamese. Not a good place to shop for dictionaries or maps, though.

Supermarkets

Although most grocery shopping still happens in street markets (see above), supermarkets and convenience stores are becoming more common. As well as local mid-level and luxury brands, many supermarkets stock imported products such as California pistachios and almonds, European cheese, chocolates and wine, Korean kim chi, or Japanese seaweed snacks. Consumer staples, such as fresh produce or tofu may be considerably more expensive than in traditional markets.

- **Winmart** (formerly named Vinmart) is a large chain of big and mini convenience stores, offering a selection of fresh products. Western goods importer **L's Place** has a few branches, including one just south of the Hoa Lo prison on Ly Thuong Kiet and focuses on the expat market.
- **Circle K** is another large chain of mini convenience stores similar to 7-Eleven, located all over Hanoi.
- **Aeon Fivimart** is a large supermarket with a central branch east of Hoan Kiem Lake (27A Ly Thai To, at Tran Nguyen Han). The huge but further afield **Lotte Mart**, located in the basement of the Lotte Center (Hanoi's second-tallest building; at the corner of Đào Tấn and Liễu Giai, a few blocks south of West Lake - the word "Lotte" on the tower makes it easy to find), may be one of the best of the breed, with a good bakery and cafeteria section. Open 08:00-22:00.
- If you've a particular desire to spend double the usual price on a selection of boutique imported Western goods (French Comte cheese, Iberico ham, British ale), **Annam Gourmet** have a store in the Syrena Centre at 51 Xuân Diệu St. in Tây Hồ. Largest selection of imported cheeses in town.

Discriminatory pricing

Most shops quote much higher prices for tourists (including Vietnamese people from other regions) than for locals, and the belief that tourists are rich and hence should pay more than locals is firmly entrenched in the local culture. As such, most vendors will insist that as a tourist, you pay the tourist price and will refuse to let you bargain the price down to the local price even if you know what it is. If you have a trusted local friend, you can save a fair bit of money by getting your friend to buy the item you want in your absence.

Eat

Hanoi's most famous (and prevalent) dish is *phở* soup: "phở gà" (chicken noodle soup), "phở bò" (beef noodle soup), or "phở chay" (tofu noodle soup). Another local specialty is *bún chả*, grilled fatty pork over a plate of white rice noodles and herbs with dipping sauce.

There are hundreds of street restaurants in small kiosks on the sidewalk, with plastic tables and chairs on the pavement. Eating at these restaurants is a great way to experience the local food and culture. It is worth mentioning that food quality, freshness, and hygiene can vary greatly. On average, a bowl of noodle soup goes for 40-60,000 dong (June 2024) and market food stalls offer fruit portions, sausages, doughnuts and other foods. Check your change as a few vendors seem to forget to give it, and learn a little Vietnamese because vendors often will not speak any or much English (e.g. "bao nhiêu ?", meaning "how much?").

Exotic treats

Next to Beijing, Hanoi is probably the second in the running to the world's exotic food paradise.

- **Snake Restaurants** (*about ten minutes across the river from the city centre, take Bus 10, 15 or 17 and get off at the large mall just beyond Gia Lâm station, and walk 500 m down the road at the right of the mall*). The suburb of Le Mat (aka Snake Village) has numerous

restaurants specializing in **cobra foodstuffs**. Live cobras are stored on the premises much the same way one would find live lobsters at a Western seafood restaurant. If one orders cobra blood wine from the menu, the waiter will take a live cobra, kill it on the spot, drain the blood into a shot glass of rice wine and top it off with the cobra's still beating heart for you to gulp down. Not for animal lovers or the ecologically-minded. Cobras are not cheap, but one snake becomes a dozen unique dishes, and enough to share between 3-4 people. *Rượu rắn* is cobra steeped whole in rice wine – or, especially in tourist areas, perhaps a cheaper, non-poisonous snake with similar coloring whose body has been stretched to give it the expected shape. Carefully investigate customs restrictions before deciding to bring a few bottles home, as some of the snakes used are endangered species.

A local delicacy in the Hanoi area is **dog meat** (*thịt chó*), which is especially popular in the winter. There are a number of dog restaurants in the Tay Ho district. Another exotic regional taste is *cà cuống*, an extract from the *belostomatid* or **giant water bug**. Just a few drops are added to noodles for the unique aroma.

Boiled **duck foetus eggs** (*trứng vịt lộn*) are sold by pedlars almost everywhere. The experience consists of the vendor cracking the egg in front of you, and peeling the shell and dropping the contents in a plastic bowl, then garnished with julienned ginger, Vietnamese coriander (*rau răm*) and sprinkled with chili sauce. You can see the severed head and beak of your chick that fell off if you are lucky enough to have your first bite from a different spot.

Street Food

Around the Beer Street

- **1 Bánh Mì Dân Tổ**, 32 Đ. Trần Nhật Duật. The sandwich is very delicious and crispy. Pretty crowded. You can also eat there at 3am and it will feel delicious. (updated Aug 2022)

Budget

Around the Beer Street

- **2 Bun Cha Ta Hanoi**, 21 Nguyễn Hữu Huân. Highly recommended if you are looking for authentic North Vietnamese Bun Cha. The food is great, bursting with flavour. Very cosy place. (updated Aug 2022)
- **3 Bánh Mì 25**, 25 P. Hàng Cá. Vietnamese Sandwiches. This is a good restaurant for a quick bite to eat near Dong Xuan Market. Lovely place and mouth watering food. (updated Aug 2022)
- **4 Little Hanoi Restaurant**, 16 P. Hàng Bè. Simple Vietnamese home-cooked food. Also amazing vegan food. The fried tofu in tomato sauce and grilled eggplant are delicious. Also a cute date spot. (updated Aug 2022)
- **5 Banh Mi Hoi An**, 98 P. Hàng Bạc. Vietnamese Sandwiches. This place is open from early morning and serves great bahn mi. Nice staff with good English skills. (updated Aug 2022)
- **6 Quán Cơm Bình Dân**, 20 P. Bảo Linh. 11:00-14:00. Inexpensive, home-cooked Vietnamese meals. Delicious and nutritious rice, clean restaurant. (updated Apr 2022)

Around the Hoan Kiem Lake

- **7 Bún Chả Đặc Kim** (<http://bunchahangmanh.vn/>), 1 Hang Manh (*Old Quarter near Hang Da Market*), ☎ +84 915 177 766, +84 24 3828-5022, +84 16 9777 6666. 08:00-19:00.
Some rate this as one of the best examples of bún chả in Hanoi, and therefore Vietnam (apparently in the south, bún chả is specifically advertised as Hanoi-style). For 100,000 dong each, you'll get a bowl full of tiny minced-pork rissoles that have been chargrilled over an open flame and a massive plate of pork rice paper rolls that have been fried in oil twice. You also get a phenomenal dipping sauce (fish sauce, made from sugar, garlic, peppers usually), a massive plate of greens and herbs and more bun (rice noodle) than you can handle. It is now more touristy than it used to be. Great food, but expect rude service. There is another **8 Bún Chả Đặc Kim** in 67 Đường Thành.
- **9 Pho 10 Ly Quoc Su**, 10 P. Lý Quốc Sư (*On the corner of Nha Chung and Chan Cam*). Serve delicious beef rice noodle, fried bread stick is crispy and delicious. The place is so clean and nice. All of the soups and sides include beef (bo), so this isn't for vegetarians. (updated Aug 2022)
- **10 Pho Tu Lun (Au Trieu)**, 34 P. Ấu Triệu. Many pho varieties. Store is only open in the morning. Locals crowd the place, so you know it must be good. (updated Aug 2022)

Near the city center

- **11 Com Chay Nang Tam Vegetarian Restaurant** (<http://nangtam.com.vn/>), 79A Pho Tran Hung Dao (*a few streets S of the lake*), ☎ +84 936 424 140, +84 24 3942-4140, comchaynangtam.hanoi@gmail.com (mailto:comchaynangtam.hanoi@gmail.com). Daily 10:00-21:00. This excellent restaurant is a good vegetarian option, and will please both vegetarians and non-vegetarians with its wide range of innovative dishes, which include fake meat dishes. Restaurant is comfortable with good ambience, and is good value. Well worth the short walk out of the old town. (updated Aug 2022)

Outside the city center

- **12 Au Lac Vegetarian Restaurant**, 277 Ng. Văn Chương (*take Le Duan S, past train tracks, turn into alley after #114*). Daily, 07:00-20:30. Typical local vegetarian restaurant like you'll find everywhere in Vietnam except Hanoi, a little off the beaten track in an atmospheric alleyway. (updated Aug 2022)

Mid-range

Around the Hoan Kiem Lake

- **13 Huyen Huong Restaurant**, 20 Bao Khanh, ☎ +84 24 3828-8430. Choose from a wide variety of seafood dishes (many of which are swimming around in tanks) and other Vietnamese specialities. Friendly staff complements the tasty food. from 80,000 dong.
- **14 Kaiser Kaffee Restaurant**, 34A Ba Trieu. Interesting little place which has excellent Vietnamese and Western food. (updated Aug 2022)
- **15 Little Hanoi**, 16 P. Hàng Bè, ☎ +84 24 3928-5333. Upscale cafe serving mainly Westerners in a pleasantly lit restaurant. (updated Aug 2022)
- **16 Mediterraneo**, 23 Nhà Thờ St., Hoàn Kiếm (*between La Salsa and Paris Deli*), ☎ +84 24 3826-6288. Daily 10:00-22:00. Authentic Italian food, probably the best you'll get in

Hanoi. Prices are steep and portions small. Mains from 195K to 490K dong (Aug 2021). (updated Aug 2022)

- **17 Moka Café**, P. Nhà Thờ (*Nha Tho St close to the cathedral*). Excellent selection of Western and Vietnamese food served in a coffee shop environment. (updated Aug 2022)
- **18 Pepperoni's**, 98 P. Hàng Trống. Part of a small international chain of pizza restaurants. Locally run, they do regular special offers such as free desserts, eat-all-you-can buffets and loyalty schemes, whereby collecting tokens with each take-out entitles you to a free pizza. Pizzas, burgers, ice cream and apple crumble. (updated Aug 2022)
- **19 01 -wan- Tantan Ramen** (<https://www.facebook.com/01wantantanramen>), 63 Lãn Ông St., Hoàn Kiếm, ☎ +84 766 645 001. Daily 11:00-22:00. Two-floor ramen shop owned by a Japanese chef, specialising in excellent tantanmen with creamy, Sichuan-inspired "numbing spicy" mala broth. Ramen bowls from 180-200k dong. (updated Mar 2025)

At the West Lake

- **20 Dalcheeni** (<http://www.dalcheenivn.com/>), 100 Xuân Diệu St., Tây Hồ, ☎ +84 24 3266-8453, dalcheenivn@gmail.com (<mailto:dalcheenivn@gmail.com>). Daily 10:30-14:30, 17:30-22:30. Authentic Indian restaurant with classy interior and good view of West Lake, frequented by Indian expats; restaurant manager is a Goa native. All meat served is halal, with extensive vegetarian options available. Highly recommend the tandoor-grilled chicken, lamb and broccoli dishes. Reservations recommended. Mains from 100K to 350K dong (Aug 2021). (updated Aug 2022)

Around the Train Street

- **21 Quán Ăn Ngon** (Delicious), 18 Phan Boi Chau St. Wide range of choices of dishes from everywhere in Vietnam at reasonable prices. Limited seating and many customers, so a wait is certain. They have a large seating area so customers do not have to wait long. Serves both lunch and dinner. (updated Aug 2022)

Outside the city center

- **22 Ramen Haron** (<https://www.facebook.com/ramenharon/>), 40 Linh Lang St, Ba Đình (*just inside Alley 2, immediately after 40 Linh Lang*), ☎ +84 832 543 165. M-Sa 11:30-13:45, 17:30-22:00. Hole-in-the-wall ramen joint in Hanoi's "Japantown", frequented by Japanese expats; some staff speaks Japanese. Excellent quality and variety of ramen at very reasonable prices. Reservations recommended due to limited seating; takeaway and home deliveries also available. Ramen bowls from 150K-170K dong (Aug 2021). (updated Aug 2022)
- **23 Tầm Vị** (<https://www.facebook.com/nhahangtamvi/>), 4B Yên Thế St, Ba Đình (*In an alley just off Nguyễn Thái Học street*), ☎ +84 966 323 131. Daily 11:00-14:00, 17:00-21:00. Vietnamese restaurant in well-preserved heritage villa, serving traditional Northern cuisine at reasonable prices. Excellent choice for first-time visitors who want authentic home-style cooking in a more upscale dining space. Inexplicably awarded a Michelin star in 2023 despite not at all being a fine dining destination, but forget about the star and you'll have a good time. To the restaurant's credit, their low prices have remained mostly unchanged since; but prior reservations are now essential. 200-300k dong per person. (updated Mar 2025)
- **24 Việt Lai Thuận** (<https://www.facebook.com/p/Nh%C3%A0-H%C3%A0ng-Vi%E1%B%87t-Lai-Thu%E1%BA%ADn%E6%B2%B3%E5%86%85%E8%B6%8A%E6%9D%A5%E9%A1%BA%E9%A4%90%E5%8E%85-61557808031532/>) (越来顺), 83 Hào Nam St, Chợ

Dừa, Đống Đa (*Turn right into Alley 83, then turn right again just before the car park for the entrance*), ☎ +84 39 865 9886. Daily 11:00-14:00, 17:00-21:00. Grand Chinese dining hall serving the best and most authentic Sichuanese cuisine in town, alongside some Cantonese options. Caters near-exclusively to Chinese group clientele, with private rooms and karaoke facilities. Servings are all very large (sized for 3-4 pax) as a result, but kitchen can accommodate requests for half-servings. 300-500k dong per person. (updated Dec 2025)

Splurge

- **25 dragonCELLO (<https://dragoncello.vn/>)**, 201 Vệ Hồ St., Tây Hồ (*three-storey building painted bright yellow; very hard to miss*), ☎ +84 24 3266-8453, restaurant@dragoncello.info (<mailto:restaurant@dragoncello.info>). Daily 11:00-23:00. Italian restaurant in grand colonial-style mansion, with commanding lakefront views of West Lake. Ground floor counter also offers extensive selection of Italian cured meats and cheese for takeaway. Risottos are especially good. Reservations recommended; home deliveries also available. Mains 215K-680K dong. (updated Aug 2021)
- **26 Etësia (<https://www.facebook.com/etesiahanoi/>)**, 14B Lò Sũ St., Hoàn Kiếm, ☎ +84 986 868 042. Daily: 17:00-21:00. Excellent contemporary European wine bar and bistro, with intimate countertop seating and dedicated cocktail bar on second floor. French head chef formerly sous chef at Michelin-starred Parisian restaurant. No tables, only 18 counter seats. Reservations recommended due to limited seating, but walk-ins also welcome. Mains 190K-890K dong. (updated Jul 2021)
- **27 Gia (<https://gia-hanoi.com/>)**, 61 Văn Miếu St., Đống Đa (*opposite the Temple of Literature's eastern wall*), ☎ +84 896 682 996, reservations@gia-hanoi.com (<mailto:reservations@gia-hanoi.com>). Lunch: F Sa 11:30–14:30; dinner: Tu-Sa 18:00–23:00. Fine dining fixed-course experience, awarded one Michelin star in 2023. Atmospheric decor and friendly, knowledgeable staff serving modern reinventions of traditional Vietnamese cuisine using local produce. Reservations essential. Tasting menu only: 10-course lunch from 1,800K dong, 12-course dinner from 2,590K dong. (updated Feb 2025)
- **28 Lamai Garden (<https://www.lamaigarden.com/>)**, 36B Đê Quai St, Tứ Liên, Tây Hồ, ☎ +84 96 1676 448. Lunch: F 11:30–15:00; dinner: M-F 18:00–23:00. Go here for a purely Vietnamese fine dining experience, without Gia's more Western-leaning influences. High-quality, farm-to-table ingredients obtained from across the north. Closed on weekends; reservations essential. Tasting menu only: lunch from 1,400K dong, 11-course dinner from 1,800K dong. (updated Dec 2025)
- **29 JW Café (<https://portal.marriott.com/hanjw-dining/jw-cafe>)**, 8 Đỗ Đức Dục St., Mỹ Trì, Nam Từ Liêm (*on ground floor of the JW Marriott Hotel Hanoi*), ☎ +84 24 3833-5588 (ext. 1125), mhrs.hanjw.fb.marketing.coordinator@marriott.com (<mailto:mhrs.hanjw.fb.marketing.coordinator@marriott.com>). Daily 06:00-22:00. Luxury buffet restaurant. Immense triple-height dining room with panoramic views of adjacent lake and National Convention Center complex. Six live stations serve Chinese, Japanese, Korean, Indian, Mediterranean, BBQ, carved meat and fresh seafood selection; Sunday brunch has unlimited abalone, lobsters, French oysters and foie gras. Attached "Chocolate Lab" makes fresh, handmade truffles on site. Reservations essential. Breakfast 690K dong, lunch 590-790K dong, dinner: 1,100-1,350K dong, Sunday brunch 1,690K dong. (updated Aug 2021)
- **30 LABRI Bistro (<http://www.labribistro.com/>)**, 113 Bùi Thị Xuân St., Hai Bà Trưng (*2nd floor of innocuous building, no external signage; ground floor is motorbike garage*), ☎ +84 931 353 113, labrihanoi@gmail.com (<mailto:labrihanoi@gmail.com>). Daily 17:00-22:00. Out-of-the-way modern French bistro with Korean touches in casual, minimalist dining room. Excellent cooking, though portions are a tad small. Korean head chef formerly worked at

Michelin-starred restaurant in Osaka. Reservations recommended. Mains 380K-680K. (updated Aug 2021)

- **Lý Club (<http://www.lyclub.vn/hanoi/>)**, 4 Le Phung Hieu, Hoan Kiem, ☎ +84 24 3936-3069, info@lyclub.vn (<mailto:info@lyclub.vn>). Daily 11:00-23:00. Top-notch Vietnamese and European cuisine in a French colonial mansion. On the expensive side for Hanoi, but the atmosphere and good quality of food make up for it. A pianist alternates with piped music. Starters 150,000 dong, mains 350,000 dong. (updated Dec 2018)
- **Pane e Vino Italian Restaurant and Wine Shop (<https://panevino.vn/>)**, 3 Nguyen Khac Can & 98 Hang Trong (100 m east of Hoan Kiem Lake), ☎ +84 24 3826-9080, +84 24 3928-6329. Daily 09:00-23:45. Serves a wide range of traditional regional Italian dishes. An extensive wine list with Italian wines from Veneto, Tuscany, Puglia, Sicilia, and Piedmont. Friendly service. A great place to relax and get recover after a long walking and shopping day. A/C within, extensive seating outside. Pizza 150,000 dong, mains 450,000 dong. (updated Dec 2018)
- **Press Club (<http://www.hanoi-pressclub.com>)**, 3rd floor, 59A Ly Thai To St, ☎ +84 24 3972-0888, fax: +84 24 3934-0899, hongngoc@hanoi-pressclub.com (<mailto:hongngoc@hanoi-pressclub.com>). Daily 11:30-14:30, 18:00-23:30. Fine dining with Western cuisine and a good selection of wines. 70-seat restaurant, private wine room for 12, and another cosy private room for 4. A combination of old and contemporary features with a classically trained chef. Mains from 900K dong. (updated Dec 2018)
- **31 Stellar Steakhouse (<https://landmark72.intercontinental.com/stellar-steakhouse>)**, 62nd Floor, Keangnam Hanoi Landmark Tower, Mễ Trì, Nam Từ Liêm (*located on 62nd floor of the InterContinental Hanoi Landmark 72*), ☎ +84 24 3698-8888, hanoilandmark72@ihg.com (<mailto:hanoilandmark72@ihg.com>). Daily 18:00-22:30. Fine American steakhouse serving a wide range of aged meats, including authentic Japanese Kobe; named Asia's Best Luxury Steakhouse in the 2019 World Luxury Restaurant Awards. Glitzy Art Deco dining room with panoramic views of the city. Large private rooms, dedicated wine & cheese tasting room, and upstairs whisky & sake lounge. Attached mezzanine-floor Stellar Teppanyaki serves its own tasting menus. Reservations recommended. Steaks 900K-3,600K dong. (updated Aug 2021)
- **32 Sushi Uminohana (<https://www.facebook.com/%E9%AE%A8%E6%B5%B7%E3%81%AE%E8%8F%AF-Sushi-Uminohana-Restaurant-102101471696602/>)** (Teppan Shu), 70 Phan Kế Bính, Cống Vị, Ba Đình, ☎ +84 933 671 131. Daily 10:00-13:00, 17:00-23:00. Authentic omakase restaurant in Hanoi's "Japantown", serving traditional sushi, sashimi and donburi; all seafood and Wagyu beef flown fresh from Japan multiple times per week. A favourite of local Japanese expats, head chef have decade's worth of experience in Japan and speaks fluent Japanese. No tables, only 12 counter seats. Second-floor Teppan Shu exclusively serves grilled Ozaki beef. Reservations essential. Lunch donburi and omakase from 750K-1,650K dong; Dinner omakase from 1,300K-2,500K dong; Teppan Shu beef from 2,500K-3,450K dong. (updated Dec 2021)
- **33 T.U.N.G Dining (<https://www.tungdining.com/>)**, 2C Quang Trung St., Hoàn Kiếm, ☎ +84 859 933 970, info@tungdining.com (<mailto:info@tungdining.com>). Daily 18:00-22:00. Hanoi's first high-end tasting menu experience. Cozy second-floor dining room, serving inventive and technically accomplished Modern Scandinavian cuisine. Reservations essential. 20-course tasting menu 1,390K-1,790K dong. (updated Jul 2021)

Sweet

- **Kem Tràng Tiền**, 54 Phố Tràng Tiền. Popular spot for ice cream on a hot day. Beware of motorbikes when entering the establishment, since it is sort of a drive-thru/drive-in ice cream shop. Recommended is the local cóm or đậu xanh flavours.

Drink

Bia hơi is abundant in the streets of the Old Quarter. At the crossing of *Ta Hien* and *Luong Ngoc Quyen*, commonly known as **Beer Street**, five separate venues fill up with travellers in the evenings. You can get more local atmosphere on some of the side streets.

Hanoi is a lively city on the weekends, but the Old Quarter closes relatively early (at midnight) on weekdays, so you might want to start your night early. Other places outside the Old Quarter stay open later and vary in closing times. Local young people gather around the cathedral located in Ly Quoc Su to have lemon ice tea (tra chanh) and sunflower seeds in street bars. After dark it gets quite crowded.

Sit on a plastic chair in front of one of the bia hoi (fresh beer) establishments which are invariably on the corners of many of Hanoi's Old Quarter streets. This preservative-free light beer is the perfect drink to sip as you watch the city's frenetic bustle. The beer costs less than 5,000 dong and gives you an excuse to relax and take photos of the passing local characters: should not be missed. In the Old Quarter, you will find that almost every corner is filled with stalls selling pho (Vietnamese noodle) and cafe (the name is not limited only to coffee, but also tea, sweets and grocery items, and even to pho).

On *Tô Tich*, a small street connecting *Hang Quat* and *Hang Gai*, you can help yourself to a refreshing fruit milkshake (*sinh tỐ*) at one of the stalls.

Breweries

If you are looking for something less watery than Bia Hoi, excellent freshly brewed Czech or German-style beer is available at several breweries, including: Hoa Vien (Czech), Goldmalt (Czech), Legend beer (German), with several branches around the city; prices are around 45,000-60,000 dong for 0.5 L. The craft beer revolution that's been simmering in Ho Chi Minh City since 2014 has been slow to reach Hanoi, but a few breweries are now coming online, although prices are higher still and 100,000 dong might not even get you 0.5 L.

- **Hoa Vien** (<http://www.hoavien.vn/webapp/home.php>). (updated Jun 2015)
- **Goldmalt** (<http://www.goldmalt.com.vn/>). (updated Jun 2015)
- **Legend Beer** (<http://legendbeer.vn/>). (updated Jun 2015)
- **Furbrew** (<http://www.furbrew.com>), 8b, Ngo 52 To Ngoc Van. 16:00-23:00. Danish-owned, Danish-style craft brewery. 80,000-100,000 dong/beer. (updated Feb 2017)

Bars

- **Green Lake (Ho Guom Xanh)**, 32 Le Thai To. A crowded bar with weekly performances by popular local singers. A place for the definitive Vietnamese entertainment scene. Has a cover charge on the weekends. Seems to combine part live singing with drag performances and a host club.
- **Mao's Red Lounge**, 30 Ta Hien, Hoan Kiem (*down the street from Tet and Cheeky Quarter*). Small, but lively bar in the heart of the Old Quarter. Has two levels, the top floor which is usually packed with Westerners smoking loads of cigarettes. Mao himself is usually in presence, playing all kinds of music from his iPod. He's extremely friendly and will strike up a conversation with anyone willing to listen.

- **Minh's Jazz Club (<http://minhjazzvietnam.com/>)**, 1 Trang Tien, Ha Noi (*alley behind the opera house*). This longtime institution of the Hanoi music scene is still run by the same Mr Quyen Van Minh. It seems to move venue every couple of years, so worth checking in advance. In 2015 it was in an alley behind the opera house. No cover charge, beers get more expensive (around 75,000 dong) shortly before the music starts at 21:00, but cocktails are the same price (around 100,000 dong). Offers food. (updated Oct 2015)
- **Standing Bar**, 170 Trần Vũ, Trúc Bạch. 16:00-00:00. Wide variety of Vietnamese craft beer, mostly from the south, but with a limited selection from the local Long Bien brewery. Despite the name, seats are available upstairs. (updated Feb 2017)
- **1 Top of Hanoi (<https://www.lottehotel.com/hanoi-hotel/en/dining/restaurant-top-of-hanoi.html>)**, 54 Liễu Giai St., Ba Đình, ☎ +84 24 3333-3016, topofhanoi@lotte.net (mailto:topofhanoi@lotte.net). 17:00-00:00. Large outdoor rooftop bar & brasserie on the Lotte Center's 65th floor, with 128 seats. One of the highest bars in the world at 272 m, with commanding 360-degree views of the entire city, live DJs on Tu-Su, and open kitchen. Best visited at sunset for Golden Hour ambiance; can get quite chilly at night due to high altitude, especially during winter, so bring outerwear if necessary. Noticeably pricier than the average bar, as to be expected. (updated Aug 2021)

Coffee

The usual Vietnamese coffee is widely available in Hanoi, but make sure you also try the local specialty **Cà Phê Trứng** (egg coffee), coffee topped with a foam of egg yolks whipped with sugar and condensed milk. Kopi Luwak is also something you will see often at coffee places and is not very expensive.

- **Highlands Coffee (<http://www.highlandscoffee.com.vn>)** (*opposite KFC*). On the 3rd floor in a ship-shaped 5-storey building (which is about to be demolished, so be quick) overlooking Hoan Kiem Lake and Vietnam's "Piccadilly Circus". Great spot to relax in scenic location where you can watch all the traffic and pedestrians go about their business below you along their outside balcony or stay inside their comfy air conditioned interior. They also serve food and beer.
- **Cong Caphe (<http://www.congcaphe.com/>)**. Several locations across the city, although the most central is probably the one at 54 Ma May. Serves various coffees, chocolates and teas including their speciality coconut coffee smoothie (around 45,000 dong). Popular with a young and relatively hip but well off crowd, and open late. (updated Oct 2015)

Sleep

Beware if arriving at your hotel on a weekend. Some streets in the Old Quarter and lake side can get closed to cars, so your taxi or minivan might have to drop you off early, leaving you to walk a bit with all your luggage.

Budget

See **common scams**; they're more prevalent at the budget end of the market, but no more in Hanoi than in other cities.

Old Quarter North of Hoan Kiem Lake

The heart of the Old Quarter - potentially noisy and busy - but closest to the bars on Ma May and Ta Hien. Ta Hien is Hanoi's unofficial backpacker street, and there are numerous backpackers' hostels nearby to cater to that market.

- **Hotel du Centre Ville** (formerly Hanoi Legend), No 47 Luong Ngoc Quyen St, Hoan Kiem (20 m from the corner of Bia Hoi), ☎ +84 24 3826-8459, centrevillehotel@gmail.com (mailto:centrevillehotel@gmail.com). Check-in: 08:00, check-out: 12:00. Central 3-star. The rooms are spacious, safe, and renovated. Some rooms have wardrobes. The floors are hard tiled and very clean. LCD TV and refrigerator. Also a heater/air conditioner (the hot water 24/7); ironing boards, hair-dryers; Wi-Fi throughout; free Internet computers in the lobby and a wonderful breakfast. Like most hotels in this area, they lock the doors late. The staff is very friendly. But for English (or French) and negotiating, you need to ask for Tuan: he is a floating manager who can be easily summoned and is a knowledgeable concierge. Booking in advance is advisable. Note two properties at this address, the other is very basic. USD12-25, breakfast included. (updated Dec 2018)
- **Sweet Family Guesthouse**, 14 Bat Su St, ☎ +84 24 3824-5732, info@hanoiguesthouse.com (mailto:info@hanoiguesthouse.com). A small hotel very popular with backpackers. Friendly and reliable staff. All rooms air-con with en suite toilet and shower. Has a sister establishment, Hanoi Guesthouse 2. B&B double USD 22. (updated Dec 2018)
- **Hanoi Rendezvous Hotel** (<http://www.hanoirendezvoushotel.com>), 31 Hang Dieu St, Hoan Kiem (200 m NW of lake), ☎ +84 24 3828-5777, bookings@hanoirendezvoushotel.com (mailto:bookings@hanoirendezvoushotel.com). Run by an Australian couple. Private en suite rooms and shared rooms. Air-con, cable TV. Fully informed and equipped travel service for all destinations in Vietnam. Friendly English speaking staff. Free beer and spring rolls on Thursday nights. Laundry service. Good music in cafe. Free Internet PCs and free Wi-Fi in rooms. (updated Dec 2018)
- **My Youth Hostel** (formerly Hanoi Youth Hostel), 5 Luong Ngoc Quyen, Hoan Kiem, ☎ +84 971 608 966. 17 rooms and dormitory with city view, air-con, satellite TV, telephone, minibar, en suite bath with tub and shower. Relaxation room on the 1st floor complete with a pool table, a dart board and a library. Free Wi-Fi, free beer, free tea, free coffee, free breakfast. (updated Dec 2018)
- **Kangaroo Hotel**, Hang Luoc St 71 (600 m north of Hoan Kiem Lake), ☎ +84 24 3825-8044, vnhnvn@gmail.com (mailto:vnhnvn@gmail.com). Check-out: 12:00. Basic 2-star in tall, ramshackle building with no lift. The rooms have comfortable beds, good hot water pressure for showers and air-con/fan combos. Amenities include satellite TV, free Internet and bathtub. Helpful staff with good English. (updated Dec 2018)
- **Little Hanoi DX2 Hostel** (<http://littlehanoihostel.com/>), 46 Hang Ga St, Hoan Kiem, ☎ +84 382 739 618, +84 24 3828-4461, +84 976 681 596. Rooms are clean and furnished with air conditioning, TV, sofa chairs, a minibar, a dresser, and a bathroom with hot and cold taps and a bath tub. High-speed Wi-Fi is available as well. The English speaking staff is friendly and knowledgeable, and can help you book tours. (updated Dec 2018)
- **Stars Hotel**, 26 Bat Su (Old Quarter), ☎ +84 24 3828-1911, +84 24 3828-1912, sales@tuntravel.com (mailto:sales@tuntravel.com). Clean rooms with bath. Breakfast available. A few min by walk to Dong Xuan Market and Hoan Kiem Lake. Free Internet in some rooms and also at dining room at ground level. (updated Dec 2018)
- **Hanoi 3B hotel** (<http://www.hanoi3bhotel.com/>), 99 Ma May St, Hoan Kiem Dist, ☎ +84 24 3935-1080, booking@hanoi3bhotel.com (mailto:booking@hanoi3bhotel.com). In the heart of the old town, clean rooms, helpful staff with a good level of English. They can also arrange transportation and tours. (updated Dec 2018)

- **1 Little Charm Hanoi Hostel (<http://littlecharmhanoihostel.com/>)**, 44 Hàng Bò, Hoàn Kiếm, ☎ +84 914 872 497, booking@littlecharmhanoihostel.com (<mailto:booking@littlecharmhanoihostel.com>). Check-in: 13:00, check-out: 11:00. Swimming pool and rooms with air-conditioning and soundproofing. Each bed has 2 lockers, reading light and other amenities. Bike rental, luggage storage, laundry services. From USD7. (updated Aug 2025)

Around the Cathedral

The narrow streets around St. Joseph's Cathedral offer a (relatively!) quieter and less hectic option than the main part of the Old Quarter, which is still only a five- to ten-minute walk.

- **2 Especen Hotel (<https://especenhotel.business.site>)**, 28-38 Tho Xuong & 41 Ngo Huyen St, Hoan Kiem (30 m from St Joseph's Church on a quiet alley off of Au Trieu St), ☎ +84 24 3824-4401, fax: +84 4 3825 9460, especen@gmail.com (<mailto:especen@gmail.com>). Check-in: 12:00, check-out: 12:00. Rooms are new, clean, bright, quiet, friendly staff. Doubles from 300,000 dong. (updated Dec 2018)
- **Vietnam Backpackers' (Original) Hostel (<http://www.vietnambackpackerhostels.com/eat-and-sleep/hanoi-the-original>)**, 48 Ngo Huyen St, Hoan Kiem (taxi to St Joseph's Cathedral, lane is one block north too narrow for vehicles), ☎ +84 24 3828-5372, info@hanoibackpackershostel.com (<mailto:info@hanoibackpackershostel.com>). Check-in: 24 hr, check-out: 24 hr. Run by two Australians who have lived there for many years. Clean air-con rooms (including female-only dorms plus double rooms), hot showers, tri-weekly BBQs on the rooftop, free Wi-Fi. All dorm beds have a large personal locker (no extra fee), shelf, and nightlight. Book in advance in high season. Dorm USD7.50, double USD30, breakfast included.
- **Central Backpackers (Original) Hostel (<http://centralbackpackershostel.com/>)**, 16 Ly Quoc Su (half a block N of the church on Ly Quic Su, in the alley next to June Fashion), ☎ +84 24 3938-1849. Check-in: 24 hr, check-out: noon. Local friendly staff. Free Internet. Some guests report questionable hygiene. Free beer every night. They have a similar "Old Quarter" hostel at 14-16 Thanh Ha Street. (updated Dec 2018)
- **Victor Hotel**, 24C Lý Quốc Sư (200 m west of Hoan Kiem Lake). Dorms have air-con, free computer use, breakfast can be added for USD1. Rooms from USD20. (updated Dec 2018)

Mid-range

An interesting alternative area to stay, is in one of the many modern apartment blocks above the giant basement level shopping mall of Times City. Apartments can be rented privately from 1 million dong per night. Ideal for families or groups of about four. Use the green electric bus route of E08 to get into the city centre.

- **3 Hanoi Guest House Royal (<http://hanoiguesthouseroyal.com/>)**, 26 Phat Loc, Hang Buom, Hoan Kiem, ☎ +84 948 617 179, booking@hanoiguesthouseroyal.com (<mailto:booking@hanoiguesthouseroyal.com>). Check-in: 14:00, check-out: 12:00. 24-hour front desk and a restaurant for complimentary daily breakfast. Featuring Victorian-inspired decor, air-conditioned rooms come with a smart TV. Fan is additionally provided. In-room safe, fast Wi-Fi, minibar and electric kettle, complimentary coffee, tea, snack are also included. All rooms have natural light and views of the Hanoi Old Town. The ensuite bathrooms come with bathtub or glass wall, hair dryer, and hot shower. +30\$. (updated Jul 2019)
- **Hanoi Club Hotel (<http://www.thehanoiclub.com/>)**, 76 Yen Phu St, Ho Tay (by West Lake near Sofitel Plaza), ☎ +84 24 3823-8115, enquiries@hanoi-club.com (<mailto:enquiries@hanoi-club.com>). A recreational club with 75 hotel rooms. Tennis courts, squash courts, fully

equipped gym, 25m pool, 48 bay golf driving range, Chinese restaurant, lounge, and cafe. Peaceful with hardly any sounds of traffic. Rooms are modern with some rooms facing the lake. Complimentary Wi-Fi in rooms. (updated Dec 2018)

- **Hanoi Eclipse Hotel (<http://www.hanoieclipsehotel.com/>)**, 24 Hang Quat St, Hoan Kiem, ☎ +84 24 3824-3423, fax: +84 24 3824-6144, sales@hanoieclipsehotel.com (<mailto:sales@hanoieclipsehotel.com>). Boutique hotel with clean and spacious rooms. Friendly staff speak English. (updated Dec 2018)
- **Hanoi Emotion Hotel (<http://www.hanoi-emotion.com/default.aspx>)**, 26 Hang Bot St, Dong Da (*just west of Temple of Literature*), ☎ +84 24 3848-9848, info@hanoi-emotion.com (<mailto:info@hanoi-emotion.com>). Large bath, rooftop restaurant, bar with city view. The hotel is especially good for business travel as the surroundings are very quiet and well-sited. (updated Dec 2018)
- **4 Hanoi Eternity Hotel (<http://www.eternityhotel.vn/>)**, 32 Yet Kieu St, Hoan Kiem, ☎ +84 24 3941-2262, info@eternityhotel.vn (<mailto:info@eternityhotel.vn>). Check-in: 14:00, check-out: 12:00. Business boutique hotel with 28 rooms, next to Hanoi train station. (updated Dec 2018)
- **Au Co Art Classic Hotel & Spa (<http://www.aucoartclassichotel.com/>)**, 52 Ngo Huyen St, Hoan Kiem District (*200 m east of Hoan Kiem lake*), ☎ +84 24 3938-6143, hanoihibiscushotel@gmail.com (<mailto:hanoihibiscushotel@gmail.com>). 3-star going on 2. Free Wi-Fi and TV. En suite all rooms, breakfast included and travel services available. USD54.
- **Hanoi Legacy Hotel** 108 Hang Bac St: good comfy place in the midst of old town. From 40 US\$.
- **Hanoi Royal Palace Hotel 2 (<http://www.royalpalacehotelhanoi.com>)**, 95 Hang Bong, Hoan Kiem, ☎ +84 24 3824-7443, booking@royalpalacehotelhanoi.com (<mailto:booking@royalpalacehotelhanoi.com>). The first incarnation was at 18A Quan Su St, now it's moved across the intersection. Quiet location. A boutique hotel with modern facilities and professional staff. TV, fan, air-con, hot shower, bathtub or Jacuzzi, and optional breakfast. In-room computer with Internet is included. (updated Dec 2018)
- **Hanoi View 2 Hotel (<http://www.hanoiviewhotel.com/>)**, 48 Ngo Si Lien Alley, Dong Da District (*just north of railway station*), ☎ +84 24 6267-9888, hanoiview2hotel@yahoo.com (<mailto:hanoiview2hotel@yahoo.com>). 2-star, basic but clean. All rooms have air-con, cable TV and Internet. Restaurant, sauna, travel agency and massage service. From USD20. (updated Dec 2018)
- **Indochina Queen Hotel (<http://www.indochinaqueenhotel.com>)**, 67 Pho Thuoc Bac St, Hoan Kiem, ☎ +84 24 3923-3993, +84 24 3923-3996, fax: +84 24 3923-3966, info@indochinaqueenhotel.com (<mailto:info@indochinaqueenhotel.com>). Rooms with satellite TV, air-con, safe, tea & coffee maker, and en suite baths. An on-site restaurant serves breakfast. Bar, car park, bicycle rental and babysitting are available. From USD20. (updated Dec 2018)
- **Lucky Hotels (<http://www.hanoiluckyhotelgroup.com/>)**, 12 Hang Trong St, Old Quarter, Hoan Kiem District, ☎ +84 24 3825-1029. Three hotels in the Old Quarter, all clean and spacious. Staff skillful with good English and courteous. Walking distance to Hoan Kiem Lake. Minibar/refrigerator, LCD cable TV and air-con. Free Internet access and Wi-Fi, restaurant and 24-hr room service. (updated Dec 2018)
- **Moon View 2 Hotel (<http://www.moonviewhotel.com>)** (formerly Hanoi Viet Hotel), 61 Hang Than St, Hoan Kiem District, ☎ +84 24 3927-4705, fax: +84 24 3927-4707. Check-in: 12:30, check-out: 11:30. 3-star with 38 rooms and suites with private balconies. USD45. (updated Dec 2018)
- **Thaison Palace (<http://www.thaisonpalacehotel.com/>)**, 7-9 Hang Voi, Hoan Kiem, ☎ +84 24 3935-1666, +84 24 3935-1612, fax: +84 24 3935-1611, infothaison1@thaisonhotel.com (<mailto:infothaison1@thaisonhotel.com>). Clean, spacious

rooms. Hotel staff is courteous, friendly and warm. Renovated & name change in summer 2018, previous reviews were abysmal. (updated Dec 2018)

- **Trung Nam Hai Hotel (<http://www.trungnamhaihotel.com/>)**, 27 Phu Doan, Hoan Kiem, ☎ +84 24 3928-8228, fax: +84 24 3928-8268, booking@trungnamhaihotel.com (mailto:booking@trungnamhaihotel.com). In Old Quarter, all bedrooms have en suite bath with tub and shower, air conditioning and heating, mini bar, free Wi-Fi, safe, flat screen TV with cable television, hairdryer. All floors can be reached by an elevator. (updated Dec 2018)

Splurge

- **5 Sofitel Legend Metropole Hanoi (<https://www.sofitel-legend-metropole-hanoi.com/>)**, 15 Ngô Quyền St., Hoàn Kiếm (*front entrance on Ngô Quyền St., back entrance on Lý Thái Tổ St.*), ☎ +84 24 3826-6919, fax: +84 24 3826-6920, h1555@sofitel.com (mailto:h1555@sofitel.com). Check-in: 14:00, check-out: 12:00. Hanoi's very first modern hotel, a grand French colonial institution opened in 1901; now part of Accor Group. Patronised by mostly older European travelers. Five restaurants serve tasty and fresh (if very expensive) French, European and Vietnamese cuisine. Rooms from USD 250 to 400; Suites from USD 650 to 3,750. (updated Aug 2021)
- **6 Capella Hanoi (<https://www.capellahotels.com/en/capella-hanoi>)**, 11 Lê Phụng Hiểu, Tràng Tiền, Hoàn Kiếm (*opposite the Sofitel Metropole's Lý Thái Tổ entrance*), ☎ +84 24 3987-8888, info.hanoi@capellahotels.com (mailto:info.hanoi@capellahotels.com). Glamorous Art Deco boutique hotel designed by starchitect hotelier Bill Bensley; latest addition to the ultraluxe Capella chain. Incredible interior and exterior decor, gorgeous artwork and marble murals, underground swimming pool and spa, colorfully plush rooms - and predictably sky-high prices (actually *more* expensive than the Metropole next door, which is quite the achievement). Worth a visit for the architecture alone, even if you're not staying here; the staff will be happy to show you around. Standard room USD 350; Suites from USD 500 to 4,000. (updated Aug 2021)
- **7 Meliá Hanoi Hotel (<http://meliahanoi.com/>)**, 44B Ly Thuong Kiet St. Rooms are big and offer views of the city. (updated Dec 2018)
- **8 Mövenpick Hotel Hanoi Centre (<https://movenpick.accor.com/en/asia/vietnam/hanoi/hotel-hanoi.html>)**, 83A Lý Thường Kiệt St., Hoàn Kiếm Dist., ☎ +84 24 3822-2800, fax: +84 24 3822-2776, hotel.hanoi@movenpick.com (mailto:hotel.hanoi@movenpick.com). Check-in: 14:00, check-out: 12:00. Beautifully renovated and modernised in 2024. 155 rooms and suites, 93 of which are non-smoking rooms and 20 connecting rooms. All rooms are equipped with LCD flat screen, wide selection of international cable TV channels. Minibar, IDD telephone, personal safe, tea and coffee making provided. Broadband cable and Wi-Fi is accessible in all rooms and throughout the public areas of the hotel. Rooms from USD 175 to 300. (updated Mar 2025)
- **9 Somerset Grand Hanoi (<https://www.somerset.com/en/vietnam/hanoi/somerset-grand-hanoi/index.html>)**, 49 Hai Ba Trung St, ☎ +84 24 3934-2342, enquiry.hanoi@the-ascott.com (mailto:enquiry.hanoi@the-ascott.com). 185 apartments that range from one- to three-bedroom layouts, and a three-bedroom penthouse. Each apartment has a kitchen, IDD telephone with a private number, and furnishings. (updated Nov 2017)
- **10 InterContinental Hanoi Westlake (<http://intercontinental.com/hanoi>)**, 1A Nghi Tam, Tay Ho District (*North end of lake, 15-min taxi ride to downtown*), ☎ +84 24 6270-8888, Res.Hanoi@ihg.com (mailto:Res.Hanoi@ihg.com). Hotel of 359 rooms and overwater pavilions with private balconies, built on stilts atop West Lake. Styled as a modernised adaptation of traditional Vietnamese architecture. Rooms from USD 100 to 200; Suites from USD 210 to 1,600. (updated Aug 2021)
- **11 Sheraton Hanoi Hotel (<http://starwoodhotels.com/sheraton/property/overview/index.html?propertyID=1484>)**, K5 Nghi Tam, 11 Xuan Dieu Rd, Tay Ho District. Large gardens

and courtyards. Rooms are furnished with traditional décor and modern amenities. From USD100. (updated Dec 2018)

- **12 Pan Pacific Hanoi** (<https://www.panpacific.com/en/hotels-resorts/vietnam/hanoi.html>) (formerly and still widely-known among locals as Sofitel Plaza), 1 Thanh Nien Rd, Ba Dinh District (*Near SE corner of West Lake*). 5-star with 317 rooms. Renowned as the most scenic hotel in Hanoi with a zigzag façade and stepped architecture. Hotel is spotless and well-maintained with very friendly staff, gets consistently good reviews. From USD 130. (updated Dec 2018)
- **13 Lotte Hotel Hanoi** (<https://www.lottehotel.com/hanoi-hotel/en.html>), 54 Liễu Giai, Ba Đình (33rd to 64th floor of the Lotte Center, opposite the Hanoi Daewoo Hotel), ☎ +84 24 3333-1000, fax: +84 24 3333-1100. Check-in: 14:00, check-out: 12:00. Modern and well-equipped Korean hotel, located atop the Lotte Center: a residential-commercial skyscraper complex with integrated luxury shopping mall and supermarket, two dozen restaurants, observation deck, and an outdoor rooftop bar. Nearby Linh Lang area is home to both the Japanese Embassy and Hanoi's Japanese expat community, with high-quality Japanese restaurants of all stripes aplenty. 15-min drive to Sword Lake. Rooms from USD 175 to 275; Suites from USD 300 to 750. (updated Aug 2021)
- **14 Hanoi Daewoo Hotel** (<http://www.daewoohotel.com/en>), 360 Kim Ma St, Ba Dinh District (3 km west of centre near zoo, 15 min by taxi from the centre of town). Luxury hotel, part of a larger apartment and business complex that includes 7 restaurants and cafés, 2 banks and a dance club. There is a large pool, exercise room, business centre with translation services and free Internet in the rooms. (updated Dec 2018)
- **15 JW Marriott Hotel Hanoi** (<https://www.marriott.com/hotels/travel/hanjw-jw-marriott-hotel-hanoi/>), 8 Đỗ Đức Dục St., Mỹ Trì Ward, Nam Từ Liêm Dist. (*adjacent to National Convention Center complex, behind the Hanoi Museum.*), ☎ +84 24 3833-5588, fax: +84 24 3833-5599, mhrs.hanjw.fb.marketing.coordinator@marriott.com (<mailto:mhrs.hanjw.fb.marketing.coordinator@marriott.com>). Enormous contemporary business hotel, with excellent selection of fine-dining restaurants (French, Cantonese, fusion Japanese and international buffet). Mainly serves corporate and events clientele, being located in the commercial Mỹ Đình area; is otherwise a long way from any major attractions (30-min drive to Sword Lake). Rooms from USD 150 to 200; Suites from USD 300 to 6,500. (updated Aug 2021)

Stay safe

Traffic

The simple act of walking can be intimidating, especially in the narrow streets around the Old Quarter. As is the case everywhere in Vietnam, traffic in Hanoi is dominated by an incredible number of motorbikes, all of which seem to be making a mad, desperate dash for something just out of reach, all of the time. There is no such thing as one-directional traffic in Vietnam.



Monks crossing the street

When you leave the curb, look not only left and right, but to the front and back. Even up and down would not be amiss. Take each step deliberately but resolutely. Patiently allow the motorbikes to pass. Don't rush and don't make any erratic movements. Stop in place if necessary but *never* walk backwards. This way the drivers are aware of you, and can anticipate your

behavior (along with all of the other motorbikes). As a rule of thumb, motorbikes will swerve around you, but cars and trucks will run you over. It may look chaotic, but be patient and pay attention and you'll be fine.

Hustles and scams

Be vigilant when taking a taxi. Drivers have been known to jump out at the destination and remove most of the bags from the trunk. While the passenger is busy putting on a rucksack the driver takes off with the remaining bags. Ask your hotel what taxi companies are reliable.

Be careful of hustler hawkers. In Vietnam, there is a two-tier pricing system, for locals and for foreigners. No other place in Vietnam is this practised more emphatically than in Hanoi (and in Ho Chi Minh City's Ben Thanh Market) where vendors charge differently according to how they gauge your net worth.

Pickpockets

You've read warnings about pickpockets a hundred times, but it's rarely as true as for Hanoi's busy and narrow Old Quarter or the Dong Xuan Night Market. The crowd, the loads of tourists, the distraction of heavy traffic and the narrow confines guarantee opportunities for thieves. And the general belief that tourists have too much money creates a moral climate in which thieves abound. Even if you're attentive, you'll get some pockets of your backpack opened, maybe even twice a day. Expect female pickpockets. Don't let them surround you. Approaching you with "Hello, I'm a student" seems to be a quite popular pick-up line for them.

Stay healthy

Public hospitals are generally poorly equipped and overcrowded, and staff tend to speak little to no English. As such, foreigners are highly advised to rely on private hospitals instead.

- **Hanoi French Hospital (<https://www.hfh.com.vn/en/home>)**. Hanoi's first private hospital, with staff who are able to speak French and English.
- **Vinmec Times City International Hospital (<https://www.vinmec.com/eng/hospital/vinmec-times-city-international-hospital>)**. First location of the Vinmec chain of private hospitals throughout Vietnam.

Connect

Telephone

- Hanoi code: area code changed from "4" to "24", and a "3" has been added in front of all 7-digit local numbers. Examples:
 - Old dialling style: 1234567 (from within the city) or 04 1234567 (inter-provincial) or +84 4 1234567 (from overseas)
 - New dialling style: 3 1234567 (from within the city) or 024 3 1234567 (inter-provincial) or +84 24 3 1234567 (from overseas)

Internet

Most regular restaurants and cafés have free Wi-Fi. It is culturally accepted to go to a coffee shop, order a drink and study/work there for a few hours.

There are also many places in the city where free public Wi-Fi is available.

Cope

Gyms

- **1 California Centuryon Royal City**, 72 Nguyen Trai St., Thanh Xuan. Has modern equipment, very clean, and staff are able to support you if you speak English. The gym is also on top of a large shopping mall if you are interested. (updated Dec 2025)
- **No Name**, 88 Hang Buom St. If you want to do some mild weight training on a budget. The gym is in very poor condition: the floor is hazardous and no one will spot you while benching so ensure your last rep you are able to place the bar back or go with a friend. The front of the gym is full of scooters and the rear wall has pictures of Uncle Ho exercising.
- **2 X-Men Gym (<https://xmengroup.vn/>)**, 91 P. Phùng Hưng (*In the Old Quarter. On the fourth floor*). 06:00-21:00. Free weights and lots of old-school equipment that works well. 50.000 dong for drop in. (updated Nov 2023)

Launderette

- **3 Lee Laundry**, 62 P. Thuốc Bắc, ☎ +84 796221191. 24/7. LG washer and dryer. Pay by credit card, Apple Pay. and QR (domestic banks). 50,000 dong for wash (30 min), 20,000 dong for each 10 min dry. (updated Aug 2025)

Embassies

-  **Argentina**, 4F, Sentinel Pl, 41A Ly Thai To St, ☎ +84 24 3831-5262.
-  **4 Armenia (<https://vietnam.mfa.am>)**, N679, 73 D5C Vuon Dao, Phu Thuong Ward, Tay Ho District, ☎ +84 24 3758-5228.
-  **Australia (<http://vietnam.embassy.gov.au>)**, 8 Dao Tan St, ☎ +84 24 3774-0100.
-  **5 Canada (<https://www.international.gc.ca/country-pays/vietnam/hanoi.aspx?lang=eng>)**, 31 Hung Vuong St, ☎ +84 24 3734-5000, fax: +84 24 3734-5049, hanoi@international.gc.ca (<mailto:hanoi@international.gc.ca>). Weekdays 08:00 - 12:00 13:00 - 16:30.
-  **China (<http://vn.china-embassy.gov.cn/eng/>)**, 46 Hoang Dieu Road, ☎ +84 24 3845-3736, fax: +84 24 3823-2826, chinaemb_vn@mfa.gov.cn (mailto:chinaemb_vn@mfa.gov.cn). For visa applications visit CVASC (https://www.visaforchina.cn/HAN2_EN/) (E-mail (<mailto:hanoicenter@visaforchina.org>))
-  **Czech Republic (<http://www.mzv.cz/hanoi/en/index.html>)**, 13 Chu Van An St, ☎ +84 24 3845-4131.
-  **Denmark (<http://vietnam.um.dk>)**, 19 Dien Bien Phu St, ☎ +84 24 3823-1888.

-  **Egypt** (http://www.mfa.gov.eg/english/embassies/Egyptian_Embassy_Vietnam/Pages/default.aspx), 63 To Ngoc Van St, Tay Ho, ☎ +84 24 3829-4999, fax: +84 24 3829-4997, egyembhanoi@yahoo.com (<mailto:egyembhanoi@yahoo.com>). 09:00-16:00.
-  **Finland** (<http://www.finland.org.vn>), Central Building, 31 Hai Ba Trung, ☎ +84 24 3826-6788, fax: +84 24 3826-6766, sanomat.han@formin.fi (<mailto:sanomat.han@formin.fi>). M-Th 08:00-12:00, 13:00-17:00, F 08:00-13:00.
-  **France** (<http://ambafrance-vn.org>), 57 Tran Hung Dao St, ☎ +84 24 3944-5700.
-  **Germany** (<http://www.hanoi.diplo.de/>).
-  **Greece**, 28 Thanh Nien Rd, Tay Ho District, ☎ +84 24 3715-2254, +84 24 3715-2263.
-  **India**, 58-60, Tran Hung Dao, ☎ +84 4 253409, +84 4 252310.
-  **Indonesia** (<http://www.kemlu.go.id/hanoi/id/default.aspx>), 50 Ngo Quyen St, ☎ +84 24 3825-3353, +84 24 3825-7969.
-  **Italy** (http://www.ambhanoi.esteri.it/ambasciata_hanoi/it/), 9 Le Phung Hieu, ☎ +84 24 3825-6256.
-  **Japan** (<http://www.vn.emb-japan.go.jp/>), 27 Lieu Giai, Ba Dinh District, ☎ +84 24 3846-3000.
-  **Laos**, 40 Quang Trung, Trần Hưng Đạo, Hoàn Kiếm. M-F 8:30–11:30, 13:00-16:00.. Visas available for most nationalities in 1-3 days from consular section on Phố Nguyễn Gia Thiều Street. (updated Nov 2019)
-  **Malaysia**, 43-45 Dien Bien Phu, ☎ +84 24 3734-3849.
-  **Netherlands** (<http://netherlands-embassy.org.vn>), 6F, Daeha Office Tower, 360 Kim Ma St, ☎ +84 24 3831-5650.
-  **Norway** (<http://norway.org.vn/>), 10F, Vincom City Towers, 191 Ba Trieu St, ☎ +84 24 3974-8900.
-  **Pakistan**, Villa 44/2, Van Bao Street, Van Phuc Diplomatic Compound, ☎ +84 24 3756-2251, fax: +84 24 3756-2253, parep-hanoi@hn.vnn.vn (<mailto:parep-hanoi@hn.vnn.vn>). M-F 0900-1700.
-  **Poland** (<http://www.hanoi.msz.gov.pl/pl/>).
-  **Romania** (<http://hanoi.mae.ro/en>), 5 Le Hong Phong St, ☎ +84 24 3734-1148, fax: +84 24 3843-0922, hanoi@mae.ro (<mailto:hanoi@mae.ro>). Also covers as the embassy of Romania for Cambodia. (updated Dec 2021)
-  **Russia** (<https://vietnam.mid.ru/>), 191 La Thanh St, ☎ +84 24 3833-6991. Visa application for foreigners on long-term visa only (3 months+).
-  **Singapore** (<http://mfa.gov.sg/hanoi>), 41-43 Tran Phu St, ☎ +84 24 3848-9168.
-  **Spain** (<http://www.exteriores.gob.es/embajadas/hanoi/es/Paginas/inicio.aspx>), 4 Le Hong Phong, Ba Dinh District, ☎ +84 24 3771-5207, +84 24 3771-5208, +84 24 3771-5209. (updated May 2019)
-  **Sweden** (<http://swedenabroad.com/hanoi>).
-  **Switzerland** (<http://www.eda.admin.ch/hanoi>), 15F Hanoi Central Office Bldg, 44B Ly Thuong Kiet St, ☎ +84 24 3934-6589.
-  **Taiwan** (https://www.roc-taiwan.org/vn_en/) (Taipei Economic and Cultural Office), ☎ +84 24 3833-5501.
-  **Thailand** (<http://hanoi.thaiembassy.org/>), 63-65 Hoang Dieu St, ☎ +84 24 3823-5092, fax: +84 24 3823-5088, thaiemhn@netnam.org.vn (<mailto:thaiemhn@netnam.org.vn>).
-  **Ukraine** (<http://www.mfa.gov.ua/vietnam>), 6 Le Hong Phong St, Ba Dinh District, ☎ +84 24 3734-4484, fax: +84 24 3734-4497, emb_vn@mfa.gov.ua (mailto:emb_vn@mfa.gov.ua).

-  **United Kingdom**, Central Bldg, 31 Hai Ba Trung, ☎ +84 24 3936-0550.
-  **United States** (<https://vn.usembassy.gov/>), 7 Lang Ha Street, ☎ +84 24 3850-5000.

Immigration office

- **Immigration Department**, 40A Hang Bai, ☎ +84 24 3826-6200. For visa extensions.

Go next

If you are the adventurous type or simply bored temporarily of the city atmosphere, then consider a circuit through the northern countryside. A round trip will take you to a lot of charming villages and through hills and valleys with charming views. Main roads are generally in good condition and you can easily do a couple of hundred kilometers a day. The villages and provinces are generally safe at night, and you get to see a lot of Vietnamese culture such as various tribespeople. While bus services are available (albeit not always reliable), a recommended alternative is to rent a bike or car and make the trip on your own. Motorbikes in decent quality can be rented and many places have suggestions for routes.

- Ha Long Bay's spectacular ocean karst topography is the most popular side-trip from Hanoi.
- The Sapa mountain region close to the Chinese border, home to ethnic minorities, gorgeous mountain scenery, and trekking paths connecting many tiny mountain villages, is the second-most popular trip. 320 km northwest from the capital, Sapa is accessible by direct private bus services from Hanoi, which now only takes 5h30 thanks to excellent new highways; or by 8-hour train journey from Hanoi Station to Lao Cai, then onward by minibus or hired motorbike.
- **Perfume Pagoda** (*can be reached by public transport (bus); tours are available anywhere in Hanoi*). An ancient Buddhist pilgrimage site about 60 km southwest of Hanoi. A full-day excursion that involves a boat trip to the main site, where you will hike (30-45 min) or take a cable car up a mountain. Near the top is a large limestone cave containing Buddhist shrines and statues. There are various other temples and grottoes along the way.
- Bat Trang, a village famous for its pottery, 9 km southeast of Hanoi. It is accessible by taking Bus 47, which originates at Long Bien. Just hop on (the bus will be clearly labelled with the number 47 and the text "Long Bien - Bat Trang". Take it to the last stop, which is directly opposite the pottery market (haggle for lower prices, and insist on paying in dong). Head back up the street to the factories to the products being made.
- Cao Bang, featuring the beautiful Ban Gioc Waterfall, is five hours away by bus, near the Chinese border.
- Cuc Phuong National Park, is the largest national park in Vietnam and an easy day-trip from Hanoi.
- Co Loa is the oldest ancient capital in the region; a little-visited site slightly northeast of Hanoi.
- Tam Coc/Hoa Lu in Ninh Binh Province, is a day trip is combining heritage tourism and natural landscape tourism. Hoa Lu is the site of the first capital of Vietnam in the 10th century, and was home to two kings, Dinh Bo Linh (Dinh Tien Hoang) and Le Hoan. There are now two shrines dedicated to these two kings. About 30 min away from Hoa Lu is Tam Coc [three grottoes], also known as Halong Bay on land. It features karst landforms



Pilgrimage boats toward the Perfume Pagoda 

surrounded by paddy fields, and is accessed by little wooden boats. Boats take about one hour. This is an excellent alternative to Halong Bay for those who have short attention spans, as the boat trip takes a mere hour versus Halong Bay tourist boats which take 5 hours. One minor annoyance involves peddlers on boats hawking their wares, and your boat rower trying to sell you embroidery.

- Dong Hoi, the first major beach city before Hue going south, sleepy but with all the necessary infrastructure; laid back, authentic and genuinely friendly, with at least half a dozen hostels, and convenient for accessing Phong Nha Ke Bang national park.
- Laos, long haul buses to Laos leave from Hanoi daily and can be booked at any travel agent or even online. Buses to Vientiane, 24 hours; Luang Prabang, 27-30 hours; Vang Vieng, 27-30 hours. You will be on the same bus as Luang Prabang, but changes buses at a small town in Lao. Going directly to Vang Vieng is a good choice for travellers looking to skip Vientiane, and just go to Luang Prabang and then onto Thailand. Buses to Southern Laos are available as well.
- China, the daily MR1 international train runs overnight from Gia Lâm station to Nanning between 21:20-10:06; the returning MR2 train runs the other way between 18:05-05:30. Adult tickets are priced around 1 million VND; children aged 4-12 gets half off, while under-4s travels for free. Groups of 6 and above gets 25% discount. Immigration checks at Đồng Đăng and Pingxiang station, respectively; a Chinese visa is required. Foreigners who entered Vietnam with an e-visa may not be allowed to buy this train route's tickets; check with Vietnam Railways for confirmation.